

HE LAUGHED FIRST.
HE UNDERSTOOD LAST.

SEVEN MINUTES

A NOVEL



BY JASON BRAM

Seven Minutes

A Novel

By Jason Bram

MYP 4 English Language and Literature

Teacher: Mr. Felix Okudzeto

This book is for anyone who has ever
hidden pain behind laughter.

Chapters

Chapter 1 — The Storage Room.....	6
Chapter 2 — Minute One.....	12
Chapter 3 — Minute Two.....	36
Chapter 4 — Minute Three.....	58
Chapter 5 — Minute Four.....	90
Chapter 6 — Minute Five.....	110
Chapter 7 — Minute Six.....	143
Chapter 8 — The Last Laugh.....	169
Chapter 9 — The Door Stayed Closed.....	198
Chapter 10 — Minute Seven.....	223
Epilogue — After the Door.....	241

Chapter 1 — The Storage Room

I died angry. Not peaceful. Not sorry. Still the same. My fists were getting red from hitting the metal door, but I reluctantly kept on hitting it anyway. The storage room was dark. At first, I thought it was a silly joke. A stupid way of getting revenge on the boy who made him look at the floor whenever he walked past him.

"Open the door!" I shouted. No answer.

I banged on the door again.

"Thomas, you coward! You think locking me in here makes you strong? Well think again, idiot!"

Still nothing. Then I smelled it.

Smoke. I turned around. The old socket near the shelf suddenly started sparking. A pile of clothes had caught on fire, and the flame was growing by the second. I stopped laughing. This wasn't a joke.

"Hello?" I shouted again, with a slight voice crack.

I put my shirt over my nose and grabbed the handle, twisting it with all my might, but it was still locked. My chest tightened. I kicked the door harder, harder, and harder, until my leg was killing me.

"Let me out," I said.

But no one came. I wanted to say I was sorry. I wanted to say I would change if the door opened. But I already know that is a lie.

Even with the smoke in my lungs, I still blamed everyone else.

Thomas for locking me in.

Sophie for being dramatic.

My teachers for always warning and advising me.

My mother for not understanding me.

God, if he was even real, for watching.

The fire grew brighter. It spread across the pile of clothes first, eating through the fabric like it hadn't eaten for days. Orange light crawled up the wall and threw strange shadows across the storage room. The shelves looked taller in the smoke. It felt like people standing around me, watching and doing nothing.

I tried to stay conscious.

I pressed my shirt tighter over my nose, but it did not help much. The smoke still found a way in. It scratched my throat. It filled my chest. Every breath felt smaller than the last.

I kicked the door again. Once. Twice. Thrice. The sound was weaker now. My leg hurt so badly I could barely stand, but I kept going because stopping felt too much like accepting my fate. I was not ready to accept it. I was not ready to become one of those sad stories people whispered and murmured about in the corridor.

Did you hear what happened to Marshall?

They found him in the storage room.

He was trapped.

No. Not me.

I was supposed to be the one people talked about because I made them laugh, because I caused trouble, because teachers said my name like a warning. I wasn't made to be helpless.

But I was.

The heat pushed closer. Sweat ran down my face and mixed with the dust on my skin. My eyes burned so badly that the room became blurry. The door, the shelves, the fire, my own shaking hands.

"Thomas!" I shouted. My voice cracked, then broke into coughing.

I hated how scared I sounded. I hated that if he was standing outside the door, he would hear it. He would know. After all those years of making him feel small, he would know exactly what helplessness sounded like coming from me.

That made me angrier than the fire.

I grabbed a metal box from the shelf and swung it at the door handle. The first hit sent pain up my arms. The second made the box slip from my hands. It crashed into the floor, spilling old files and loose papers across the concrete.

Some of the papers slid toward the fire. For a second, I just stared at them. Then they caught on fire. The flames jumped higher. That was when I understood. Not fully. Not bravely. Not peacefully.

I understood it the way an animal understands a trap after it's too late to get out. I was going to die here. In a storage room. Alone.

Not because I had saved anyone. Not because I had done something brave. Not because my life had reached some meaningful ending. All because I had pushed someone until they finally pushed back. My knees weakened.

I stepped away from the fire, but my shoe landed on something smooth. A folder. A plastic cover. Maybe one of the papers that had fallen from the metal box.

My foot slipped. For one horrible second, my body floated.

My arms reached for the shelf, for the wall, for anything that could keep me in the world a little longer. I caught nothing.

The back of my head struck the concrete floor. Hard. The sound was not loud. That surprised me. I thought death would sound bigger. Instead, it

was a dull crack, followed by a silence so deep that even the fire seemed far away.

The ceiling swam above me. Smoke rolled over it in dark waves. The orange light flickered at the edges of my vision. My mouth opened, but no words came out. Not an apology. Not a prayer. Not even another insult. Just air. Not enough of it.

Then the room faded away slowly, like a movie effect. The fire became light. The smoke became a shadow. The pain became distant. And suddenly I was not on the floor anymore.

I was small.

I was barefoot.

I was holding a yellow plastic toy car with one missing wheel.

I was a kid again.

Chapter 2 — Minute One

I was seven years old.

The smoke was gone. The locked door vanished. The burning in my chest disappeared too, as if my body had been left behind with the fire. For a moment, I forgot I was dying.

I forgot the storage room, the shouting, the heat, and the way my fists had hurt from banging against the door. I did not know if I was dead. I did not know if my brain was replaying my memories one last time before I finally die. I didn't know if this was a dream, a punishment, or something in between.

All I knew was that I was standing in the backyard of our old house, barefoot on the warm concrete pavement, holding a yellow toy sports car with one missing wheel.

The afternoon sun pressed against my skin. Somewhere nearby, my mother was cooking, and the smell of food drifted through the open kitchen window. It was the kind of smell that made a house feel alive. Not perfect. Not quiet. Just alive.

The backyard was smaller than I remembered. In my mind, it had always been wide, almost endless, like a whole world belonged behind our house. But now that I was inside the memory, I could see the cracked concrete, the low wall, and the old plastic chair my father always sat on when he wanted to look serious.

Still, to a seven-year-old me, it was enough. It was a kingdom. And I was standing in the middle of it with my broken yellow car, acting like I ruled everything.

My little sister, Jenna, sat on the ground in front of me, clapping her small hands.

"Again, Marshall!" she shouted. "Do it again!"

I looked down at myself. My knees were dusty. My shorts were too small for my legs. My shirt had a faded superhero design on the back. One of my slippers was missing, but I didn't care. I looked small, smaller than I remembered ever being.

I looked happy. I felt it too. That was the strangest part.

Not powerful. Not popular. Not feared. Not watched by a whole classroom waiting for my next joke.

Just happy.

I placed the broken toy car on the concrete and pushed it forward. Because it only had three wheels, it did not move straight. It shook, swerved, and turned in different directions like it had no idea where it was going. I made a loud engine sound with my mouth.

"Vroooooom! Move aside! Make way! Important president coming through!"

Jenna burst into laughter. Her laugh was bright and small, the kind of laugh that came from the stomach and took over the whole body. She leaned backward, clapping harder, her eyes shining like I had done something amazing.

It was not the fake laughter I got from my "friends" at school when we were fooling in class, disturbing others and acting like bad grades were something to be proud of. It was not the kind of laughter that came from hurting someone else. It was not the nervous laughter people gave when they were scared of my presence.

It was real laughter.

Actual laughter.

I liked the sound of it.

So I decided to do more.

I got up from the ground, waved my arms in the air, and pretended the car had crashed into an invisible wall.

"Oh no!" I shouted.

"The president has crashed into a giant bowl of soup!"

My sister laughed so hard she rolled onto her side.

I laughed too, not because I was trying to prove anything, but because her joy pulled mine out of me. It was easy then. Being funny was easy. Being loved was easy. I did not have to sharpen my words. I did not have to embarrass anyone. I did not have to make someone else smaller so I could feel taller.

All I had to do was be silly.

From the kitchen, my mother called, "Leave your sister alone before she chokes."

But she was laughing too.

I turned around.

My mother stood at the kitchen doorway with a wooden spoon in one hand. She looked younger than I remembered. Her face was softer, not yet tired in the way it became later. There was flour on the side of her cheek, and her apron was tied tightly around her waist.

I had forgotten that version of her.

The version who laughed before she sighed.

The version who looked at me like I was a blessing, not a warning.

The version who called me her little comedian instead of a problem child.

"Mummy, watch this one," I said.

I put the toy car on my head and walked slowly across the backyard like a king carrying his crown. I lifted my chin, stretched one arm out like I was beating an invisible crowd, and made my voice deep.

"My people," I announced, "your president has arrived safely after surviving the soup accident."

Jenna screamed with laughter again.

My mother shook her head, but she smiled.

"You see this boy?" she said. "Always performing."

I smiled too. Not because I wanted to embarrass anyone, not because I wanted power, just because laughter made the house feel warm. For a few seconds, the memory stayed like that. Golden. Soft. Almost kind.

The sun on my skin. Jenna's laughter. My mother in the doorway. The broken yellow car balanced on my head.

For a few seconds, I thought maybe the memory had brought me here to save me. Maybe this was what dying was. Maybe your brain did not punish you. Maybe it gave you the best parts first. It was like saying, *Look. You were loved once.*

Then my father came outside. The mood of the memory changed the moment he appeared.

Not completely. The sun was still shining. Jenna was still sitting on the ground. The smell of food still floated through the air. But something shifted, as if the whole backyard had suddenly remembered to be quiet.

My father stood by the door, holding his phone in one hand and a newspaper in the other. He wore a plain white shirt and boxers, like he had nowhere to go, but his face looked serious enough for a business. Happiness always needed permission before entering a room he was in.

"What is all this noise?" he asked.

Jenna stopped laughing first. That was how powerful his voice was. It could enter a place before he did. It could touch people before his hands ever moved.

My mother turned slightly toward the kitchen. Her smile did not disappear at once. It faded slowly, like she was trying to keep it alive but failed.

I stood there with the toy car still balanced on my head.

"It's just play," my mother said gently.

My father looked at me.

"Marshall, is that what you do with your life? Play?"

I did not understand the question then. I was just seven. Life was not something I was supposed to do something yet. Life was simply cereal in the morning, toys, dusty knees, cartoons, and making Jenna laugh until she forgot how to breathe properly.

So I smiled.

"I'm a president," I said, pointing at the car on my head.

Jenna giggled quietly, but the laugh died in her throat before it even came out. My father did not smile.

"Presidents read," he said. "Presidents think. Presidents don't behave like clowns." The word landed harder than it should have.

Clown.

At school, people would call me funny. Crazy. Wild. Troublesome. They would say I made class interesting. They would say nothing was boring when I was around. They would say I could turn any serious moment into a joke.

But my father was the first person who made laughter sound like a weakness. Slowly, I took the toy car off my head.

"I was joking, Daddy," I said.

"That is always your answer," he replied, even though I was only seven and hadn't lived long enough to give a better answer.

"Just joking. Just playing. Just wasting time instead of being useful to society."

Useful to society. I did not even know what that meant. I only knew it sounded like something I was failing at. My mother came back to the doorway.

"He is a child," she said.

"He will not be a child forever."

"He does not have to be serious every second."

My father turned his head toward her. The movement was small, but the warning inside it was not. My mother went quiet.

That was another thing I remembered as I stood inside the memory: silence was not empty in our house. Silence had weight. Silence had rules. Silence was what happened when someone had something to say, but swallowed it because the cost of speaking was too high.

My father stepped closer.

"Come here."

I walked to him. Each step felt heavier than the last. I did not know what I had done wrong. I only knew that the laughter had disappeared, and somehow, it was my fault.

He pointed to the chair beside him.

"Sit."

I sat. The plastic chair was warm from the sun. My legs were too short to rest properly, so my feet hovered slightly above the ground. I held the yellow car tightly, pressing my fingers around it like it could protect me.

"Count from one to hundred."

I blinked. "Now?"

"Of course now. Don't be an idiot."

Idiot. The word landed in my chest and stayed there. It felt worse than being called a fool because it sounded more certain. But I acted like it didn't bother me. Because even then, I already believed hurt was something you were supposed to hide.

Behind me, Jenna whispered, "Marshall..."

I looked back at her and made a silly face. Her mouth twitched as she tried not to laugh. My father snapped his fingers.

"Face front."

I faced front.

"One," I began, "Two. Three. Four."

My voice sounded small. I hated how it sounded.

By the time I reached twenty, I had stopped thinking about the numbers. I was thinking about how quickly people could change. One moment, they were laughing with you. The next, they were looking at you like you just ruined their entire day.

"Louder," my father said.

"Twenty-one. Twenty-two. Twenty-three."

I counted louder. Not because I understood why. Because his voice made obedience feel safer than questions.

When I reached fifty, my throat was dry. When I reached seventy, I could hear Jenna moving behind me, shifting on the concrete. When I reached ninety, I began to hope it was almost over.

"One hundred," I finally said.

For one tiny second, I thought I had done well. I looked up, waiting for him to say something. Anything. A small "good." A nod. Some sign that I had finally done what he wanted. Instead, he handed me the newspaper.

"Read the headline."

The letters looked too big and too serious. I knew some words, but not all of them. My eyes moved across the page, searching for something I could understand.

The newspaper smelled like ink and dust. The paper was thin and rough beneath my fingers. I remember that clearly. I remember the way my hands began to sweat. I remember how the words seemed to look more confusing the longer I stared at them.

"Government..." I began slowly. "Promises..."

The next word trapped me. I stared at it. The letters sat there, silent, and stubborn, refusing to become a word in my mouth. My feet squirmed against the floor. My ears became hot.

"What does it say?" he asked.

I swallowed. The word did not appear. The whole backyard waited.

"I don't know."

The words came out small.

For a second, nobody moved. Then my father stood up. The chair scraped against the floor, loud enough to make Jenna stop breathing. My mother's hand tightened around the edge of the doorway.

My father looked down at me in anger.

"You don't know?" he repeated.

I shook my head.

"I tried."

"You tried?"

His voice was calm, but somehow that was worse than shouting.

"You can make noise. You can jump around like a clown. You can waste everybody's time. But when I ask you to do one serious thing, suddenly your brain goes empty."

My throat tightened.

"I'm sorry."

The words came quickly, almost by themselves. I did not even know if I meant them. I only knew that *sorry* was sometimes the key that unlocked trouble before it even reached you.

But not that day. My father snatched the newspaper from my hands and threw it onto the chair.

"Stand up."

I stood. My legs felt weak.

My mother stepped forward.

"Please. He is only a child."

"That is the problem," my father said. "You keep treating him like a baby. That is why he has no discipline."

"He made a mistake."

"He is becoming a mistake."

The words hit before his hand did. I did not understand the full meaning, not then, but I felt it. I felt it in my stomach. I felt it in my throat. I felt it in the sudden silence that swallowed the backyard.

Then his hand came across my face.

It was fast.

A sharp sound cracked through the air.

For one second, I did not feel pain. I only felt surprise. My head turned to the side, and my whole world tilted with it. Jenna made a tiny sound behind me, like she had swallowed a scream.

Then the sting came.

Hot. Humiliating. Real.

My eyes filled with tears immediately, but I forced them back. I stared at the ground because I knew if I looked at anyone, the tears would fall.

"Marshall!" my mother cried.

She moved toward me, but my father pointed at her.

"Do not interfere."

The words cut through her movement. She stopped halfway, close enough to reach me but not close enough to help. That was the part I remembered most. Not just the slap. The distance.

My mother was only a few steps away, but fear kept her frozen where she stood.

She is right, I wanted to say. I am just a kid. I am only seven. But I said nothing.

My father crouched slightly so his face was closer to mine.

"Look at me."

I did not.

"Marshall."

I lifted my eyes.

His face was not angry in the way children imagine anger. He was not wild or out of control. That made it worse. He looked certain. Like this was not cruelty to him, but rather a lesson.

"Life will not reward you for being funny," he said.

"Nobody respects a fool."

I swallowed. "Yes, sir."

"You think jokes will put food on the table? You think being a clown will make people proud of you?"

"No, sir."

My cheek burned. My chest burned more.

Jenna was now crying now, quietly, with both hands pressed over her mouth. She looked scared, like even her sadness might get her punished.

I looked at her for half a second.

That was my mistake.

My father noticed.

"Face me when I am speaking to you."

"I am," I whispered.

"You are what?"

"I am, sir."

He raised his hand again. This time, I flinched before he even touched me. He saw it. Something like satisfaction passed across his face. Then he slowly lowered his hand.

That was almost worse than being hit again, because it taught me something new.

Fear could be used as a leash. You did not always need to pull it. Sometimes people only needed to know it was there.

My mother stepped in between us.

"That is enough!" she said, but her voice shook.

My father looked at her for a long moment. Then he picked up the newspaper and pushed it against my chest.

"Go inside," he said. "Read the headline until you can say every single word."

I took the paper. My fingers were shaking so badly that the pages rattled in my hands.

I walked toward the house, but I stopped when I reached the doorway. I don't know why I turned back. Maybe I wanted my mother to run after me. Maybe I wanted my father to say he was sorry. Maybe I wanted Jenna to laugh again and make everything feel lighthearted like before.

But nobody moved. My mother stood frozen, her eyes wet. Jenna was still crying beside the broken toy car. My father sat down as if nothing important had happened.

So I went inside.

The house was cooler, but I felt hotter. I sat at the dining table with the newspaper spread in front of me. The letters blurred because my eyes would not stay dry.

Government promises...

The difficult words were still there, waiting for me. I hated them. I hated the quiet. I hated my father's voice still living inside my head.

Nobody respects a fool.

I wiped my eyes quickly with the back of my hand.

Then I forced myself to laugh. It was small at first. Just one breath. Then another. It didn't sound funny at all. It didn't sound happy either. It barely sounded like me. But I kept doing it anyway.

I laughed because crying felt dangerous. I laughed because sadness made me feel weak. I laughed because if I turned the pain into a joke, maybe it would stop feeling like pain. From that day, I started learning the wrong lesson.

I learned that if people laughed, they could not see your fear. I learned that if you acted like nothing hurt you, people wouldn't even bother to hurt you anymore. I learned that power could sound like laughter.

I sat at the dining table until the words on the newspaper stopped looking like words. My cheek still burned, but I refused to touch it. Touching it would mean admitting that it hurt.

So I smiled instead. Not a real smile. A fake one. The kind of smile that said, *I don't care*, even when I did.

Outside, Jenna was quiet. So was my mother. The whole house felt like it was holding its breath.

I looked down at the newspaper again. The headline still did not make sense. But my father's words did.

Nobody respects a fool.

I did not know it then, but those words followed me for years. They sat in the back of my mind every time a teacher corrected me. Every time someone laughed at me instead of with me. Every time I felt small and worthless.

And each time, I laughed louder.

The memory flickered.

The backyard blurred at the edges. My mother's face faded. Jenna's small hands disappeared. The broken yellow car became a shape, then a color, then nothing at all.

But one feeling stayed. Shame.

It followed me out of that memory like a shadow. And before the next memory began, I understood one thing. I was not born cruel. I had learned how to hide.

And laughter was the first thing I used to hide myself.

Chapter 3 — Minute Two

By the time I was nine, I had already learned that laughter could change a room.

It could make teachers pause in the middle of a sentence. It could turn a boring lesson into something worth watching. It could make children turn around in their chairs and look at me like I mattered. It made me feel like I wasn't just another boy in the back row with messy handwriting and unfinished work.

Most of all, laughter could make me feel powerful.

The memory opened inside my primary school classroom, bright with morning light and already loud with children who were restless before the day had even begun. Sunlight poured through the windows and spread across the floor in pale squares. The fans above us turned slowly, barely cooling the room.

Colorful posters covered the walls. The alphabet stretched above the whiteboard in big cheerful letters. A times table chart hung crookedly near the cabinet. Near the door, there was a poster about kindness, decorated with smiling cartoon faces and words like **respect**, **honesty**, and **empathy**.

Nobody really looked at it.

I sat near the back of the classroom with Justin and Caleb. They were not exactly my best friends yet, but they laughed at almost everything I did, and at that age, that was enough. Their laughter made me feel bigger. Braver. Less alone.

Justin was the kind of boy who laughed loudly even when he didn't understand the joke. Caleb was quiet, but once Justin started laughing, he always followed. Together, they made a small audience, and I had already learned that an audience could make me feel taller than I really was.

Ms. Carter stood at the front of the class, writing spelling words on the board. Her handwriting was neat and careful, the kind of handwriting teachers always seemed to have, like even their letters knew how to behave.

"Everybody copy these into your notebooks," she said.

"Quietly, please."

Most of the class bent their heads and started writing.

I did not.

I tapped my pencil against the desk.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Ms. Carter turned around.

"Marshall," she said, "please stop tapping."

I stopped immediately and gave her my most innocent smile.

"Yes, Ms. Carter."

A few students giggled. Ms. Carter looked at me for a second longer, as if she already knew the silence would not last. Then she turned back to the board.

The tapping started again. This time, softer.

Justin's shoulders shook with silent laughter.

Caleb whispered, "You're actually crazy."

I smiled to myself. That was all I wanted. Attention. To be noticed. To be the reason something happened.

Near the front of the classroom sat a boy named Daniel. Daniel was quiet, neat, and careful. His shirt was always tucked in properly. His handwriting looked like it belonged on a school poster. He raised his hand before speaking, even when everyone already knew he had the answer.

I did not hate Daniel at first. That was the truth.

Daniel had never done anything to me. He had never insulted me, pushed me or laughed at me. He had never even looked at me in a way that should have made me angry.

But Daniel reminded me of everything adults praised.

Good manners. Good grades. Quiet behavior. Correct answers. Daniel was the kind of boy teachers smiled at. I was the kind of boy teachers sighed at.

That was enough.

Ms. Carter pointed to one of the words on the board.

"Can anyone use the word *important* in a sentence?"

Daniel's hand went up. Of course it did.

Ms. Carter smiled. "Yes, Daniel?"

Daniel stood beside his desk. His voice was soft, but clear.

"It is important to listen to someone when they are speaking."

A few students nodded. I rolled my eyes. Justin saw me and grinned. That grin was all the permission that I needed. I leaned back in my chair and whispered loudly enough for half of the class to hear.

"It is important to stop acting like a teacher's pet."

The room changed. At first, there was only a tiny sound. One person laughed through their nose. Then Justin burst out laughing. Caleb followed.

Soon, one laugh became many, moving across the back row until everyone around me was laughing.

Daniel froze. His eyes dropped to his desk.

Ms. Carter's smile disappeared.

"Marshall."

The way she said my name should have warned me. But all I felt was laughter.

It rushed through me fast. For one perfect second, I was not the boy who got corrected. I was not the boy whose father made him feel useless. I was not the boy who felt small whenever adults asked him to read, think, behave, or improve. I was the boy everyone was watching.

Daniel sat down slowly.

His ears had turned red. I noticed. And instead of feeling bad, I felt something else. Strong.

Ms. Carter walked toward me.

"That was unkind," she said.

I shrugged. "I was just joking."

The class went quiet, but Justin still had a smile on his face. I could see it from the corner of my eye, and that smile mattered more to me than Ms. Carter's disappointment.

Ms. Carter stopped beside my desk.

"A joke is not funny when it hurts someone."

I looked at Daniel, who was staring down at his notebook.

"He's not hurt," I said. "He's fine."

Daniel did not look fine. His pencil was pressed so hard into the page that the tip broke.

Ms. Carter lowered her voice.

"You do not get to decide how your words make someone feel."

I looked away.

I hated the way she spoke to me. Calm. Serious. Like she could see something inside me that I was trying to hide. Like she knew there was more underneath the joke than I wanted anyone to notice.

"I said I was joking," I muttered.

"And I am telling you it was not acceptable."

The class was silent now. I could feel everyone listening. That made it worse. A moment ago, they were laughing with me. Now they were watching me get corrected like a little child.

Shame crawled up my neck. My face grew hot. I wanted to disappear.

Then I heard Justin whisper, "Ms. Carter is so dramatic."

A few students laughed again. Small laughter. Careful laughter. But it was enough.

I leaned back in my chair and gave Ms. Carter a lazy smile.

"Okay, Miss. I'll be nice."

The way I said *nice* made Justin laugh again. Ms. Carter's face tightened.

"Move your seat to the front."

The class made that low, excited sound children make when someone gets in trouble. It was not laughter exactly. It was more like anticipation. Everyone was waiting to see what would happen next.

I stood up slowly, dragging my chair across the floor louder than necessary. The metal legs screamed against the tiles.

"Careful with the chair," Ms. Carter said.

I lifted both hands. "Sorry. The chair is emotional."

The laughter came back. Louder this time. Even some of the quiet students laughed. Ms. Carter did not. Daniel did not.

I carried my books to the front of the class and sat at the desk closest to the board. I could feel Ms. Carter behind me. I could feel Daniel a few rows back. I could feel the whole class trying not to smile.

I should have felt embarrassed. Instead, I felt proud. Because even after being corrected, I had still won. At least, that was what I thought.

The lesson continued, but I did not listen. I stared at the spelling words on the board, though they barely made sense to me anymore. My mind replayed the moment again and again.

Teacher's pet. The laughter. Daniel's red ears. Ms. Carter's serious face. The power of it frightened me a little, but also excited me.

I had discovered something. Something simple. Something dangerous.

If people were laughing, they were not laughing at me. They were laughing at someone else.

And that meant I was safe.

For the rest of the morning, I kept glancing back at Daniel. He did not raise his hand again. When Ms. Carter asked another question, his eyes stayed on his notebook. His shoulders were tight, like he was trying to make himself invisible.

I saw all of that. I saw it clearly. But I told myself it didn't matter. I told myself he was too sensitive. I told myself people needed to learn how to take a joke.

That was another thing I was learning to do: turn someone else's pain into their problem.

At break time, I walked outside with Justin and Caleb. The playground was hot and loud, filled with shouting children, bouncing balls, and shoes scraping against the ground. The air smelled like dust, lunchboxes, and the rubber of the football rolling across the field.

Justin punched me lightly on the arm.

"That teacher's pet line was crazy."

Caleb laughed. "Daniel looked like he was about to cry."

I smiled. "He always acts like he's better than everyone else."

Justin nodded quickly. "Exactly."

But I needed him to be guilty of something. If Daniel had done nothing wrong, then I would have to admit that I had been cruel for no reason. So I made Daniel the problem.

"He thinks he's special," Caleb said.

I hesitated. Only for a second.

That second mattered, though. Somewhere inside me, a smaller part of myself knew I should stop. I remembered Ms. Carter's words.

A joke is not funny when it hurts someone.

I looked at Daniel again.

He seemed smaller on that bench than he had in class. The playground was full of noise, but he sat in the middle of it like the noise couldn't reach him. His shoulders were curved inward, and his lunchbox rested on his knees like a shield.

For one moment, I thought about leaving him alone.

Then Justin said, "Unless you're scared."

My hesitation disappeared.

I walked toward Daniel. Justin and Caleb followed behind me like an audience. Daniel saw us coming and looked down quickly.

That should have been enough to make me turn away. It did not. I stopped in front of him.

"Why are you sitting all alone?" I asked.

"Waiting for the teachers to adopt you?"

Justin laughed first. Then Caleb. Daniel gripped his lunchbox.

"Leave me alone," he said quietly.

I tilted my head.

"What was that? I can't hear you when you talk like a mouse."

Daniel stood up.

"I said leave me alone."

For a moment, I saw something in Daniel's eyes that surprised me. Not fear.

Anger. Real anger. I didn't like it.

His anger made him look less small, and I did not want that. I wanted him embarrassed. I wanted him silenced. I wanted him to stay in the place I had pushed him into.

So I stepped closer.

"Or what?"

Daniel's mouth opened, then closed again.

Nothing came out. I smiled. That smile felt different from the one I used when I was younger, when I made Jenna laugh in the backyard. It wasn't warm. It didn't make anyone happy.

It was sharp. It was a weapon.

"That's what I thought," I said.

Daniel walked away. Justin and Caleb burst out laughing behind him. I laughed too. But as Daniel crossed the playground, I noticed the way his shoulders curved inward again, like he was trying to fold himself into something smaller.

For one second, I felt a strange twist in my stomach. It was not guilt exactly. Not yet. It was more like recognition.

I knew what it felt like to want to be smaller. I knew what it felt like to be helpless while someone else had power over you. I knew what it felt like to have someone look down at you and decide you were nothing.

That should have stopped me. Instead, it made me laugh louder.

Because if I let that feeling grow, I would have to remember where I had felt it first. And I did not want to remember my father.

I did not want to remember the newspaper, the chair, the sting across my cheek, or the way Jenna had cried with her hands over her mouth.

So I crushed the feeling before it could become anything at all.

I laughed until Justin laughed harder. I laughed until Caleb slapped my shoulder. I laughed until Daniel disappeared to the washroom.

By the end of the day, Ms. Carter asked me to stay behind.

The classroom emptied slowly. Chairs scarpd. Bags zipped. Children rushed toward the door, happy to be free. Justin passed my desk and widened his eyes dramatically, like I was being sent to prison.

"Good luck," he whispered.

Caleb snorted.

I smirked at them, pretending I did not care.

When the last student left, the room became too quiet.

That was when I hated classrooms the most. Not when they were loud. Loud classrooms felt calm in a way. You could hide inside noise. Quiet classrooms had nowhere to hide.

Ms. Carter sat across from me.

For a moment, she said nothing. For a moment, she said nothing. That made me uncomfortable. Adults usually filled silence with shouting or lectures. Ms. Carter only looked tired.

"Marshall," she said at last, "you are more clever than you pretend to be."

I frowned. That was not what I expected. I expected anger. A warning. Maybe a note sent home. I expected her to say I was rude, disruptive, disrespectful — all the usual words adults liked to use on me.

But clever? That word felt uncomfortable.

"You use jokes to control the room," she continued. "You know exactly when people are watching. You know exactly what will make them laugh."

I stared at the floor.

"That is not the same as being funny," she said gently.

I didn't answer.

"Being funny can be a gift," she continued. "It can make people feel comfortable. It can make hard days easier. But when you use people for laughter, you start losing the part of yourself that knows when to stop."

I picked at the corner of my notebook.

"I didn't do anything that serious."

"You embarrassed Daniel."

"He'll live."

Ms. Carter's eyes saddened.

"That is not the point."

I shrugged.

"It was just a joke."

Ms. Carter leaned forward.

"No, Marshall. It was a choice."

I looked up then. The word stayed in the air between us.

Choice. I hated it.

A choice meant responsibility. A choice meant I could not blame Daniel for being weak, or Justin for laughing, or Ms. Carter for being dramatic. A choice meant it had come from me.

So I rejected it.

I pushed my chair back and grabbed my bag.

"Can I go now?"

Ms. Carter watched me for a moment.

"Yes, she finally said. "But think about what I said."

I walked to the door. I didn't think about it. Not properly.

Outside, Justin and Caleb were waiting by the gate. They leaned against the wall like they had been expecting a show.

"What did she say?" Justin asked.

I smirked. "She said I'm too powerful."

They laughed. And I laughed with them.

For the rest of the day, I carried that laughter like proof that I had won. I told myself Ms. Carter was too sensitive. I told myself Daniel needed

to toughen up. I told myself Justin and Caleb understood me better than any adult ever could.

But even then, some part of me knew the truth. Ms. Carter had seen me. Not the version of me who made people laugh. Not the version who leaned back in his chair and smiled like nothing mattered.

She had seen another version hidden underneath. The boy who was afraid of being laughed at. The boy who learned to strike first.

The memory began to fade there, but the feeling remained.

The playground dissolved first. Then Ms. Carter's classroom. Then the colorful posters, the kindness chart, the spelling words on the board. Daniel's red ears, his broken pencil, his bent shoulders — all blurred into the distance.

But the lessons stayed. Not Ms. Carter's lesson. The wrong one. The one I chose for myself.

Hurting people could make others laugh.

Laughter could make me feel powerful.

And power, even the cruel kind, felt better than shame.

Chapter 4 — Minute Three

By the time I was twelve, I had become very good at pretending.

I could pretend I had done my homework by opening my notebook and acting busy whenever a teacher walked past. I could pretend I understood the lesson by copying the person beside me and nodding at the right moment. I could pretend bad grades were funny by holding up my test paper like a certificate and laughing before anyone else did.

I could pretend teachers did not annoy me.

I could pretend my father's words did not follow me after he left the room.

I could pretend I didn't care.

But church was different.

Church was the one place where pretending was supposed to disappear. People called it faith. They called it worship. They called it worship. They called it surrender. To me, it looked like a room full of people closing their eyes and trying very hard to connect with something they couldn't prove was there.

The memory opened on a Sunday morning.

I knew it was Sunday before I even saw the church. Because Sundays in our house had their own kind of pressure. They were not peaceful, not really. They were polished. Clean shoes by the door. Ironed clothes hanging behind bedroom doors. My mother's voice moving from room to room, asking if everyone was ready. My father standing near the front door, checking his watch as if God Himself was waiting to mark us late.

That morning, I had taken too long to get dressed. Not because I could not find my shirt. Not because I had overslept.

Because I had been sitting on the edge of my bed, staring at my reflection in the wardrobe mirror, wondering why everyone else seemed to know what they believed.

My white shirt felt too tight around my neck. My trousers were stiff from ironing. My shoes had been polished so much that they caught the light from the window. I looked like the kind of boy adults wanted to see on a Sunday morning.

Respectable. Quiet. Obedient. Everything I was supposed to be.

Nothing like how I felt.

"Marshall!" my father called from downstairs.

His voice hit the walls before it reached me.

I stood up quickly, grabbed my Bible from the desk, and ran my hand over the cover. It was black, with my name written inside the first page in my mother's careful handwriting. She had given it to me when I was younger and told me it would guide me.

I had never told her that most of the time, when I opened it, I felt nothing.

Not hatred.

Not rebellion.

Just nothing.

It had not always been like that.

When I was younger, I used to believe because my grandfather believed. Grandpa believed in God like he could see Him sitting in the chair beside him. He prayed before meals, before sleeping, before travelling, even

before fixing things around the house. He used to place one hand on my head and say, "God hears even the quietest voice, Marshall."

I believed him then.

Not because I understood faith, but because I trusted him.

Grandma was different. She did not speak about God as loudly as Grandpa did. She showed it in smaller ways. She would hum hymns while cooking, whisper prayers when someone was sick, and tell Jenna and me that heaven was where tired people finally rested.

Then Grandpa got sick.

Everyone prayed.

Grandma prayed until her voice became thin. My mother prayed with both hands covering her face. My father prayed like he was giving instructions. I prayed, though I did not know what I was doing. I asked God to let Grandpa stay.

But Grandpa died anyway.

After the funeral, people kept saying he was "in a better place." They said God had a plan. They said we should not question His timing.

But nobody explained why the plan had to hurt so much.

Nobody explained why a man who believed with his whole heart still had to leave.

That was when the questions started.

At first, they were small.

Then they grew.

And by the time I was twelve, all that was left inside me was distance.

That was the part I could not explain.

If I hated it, at least that would be a feeling. If I was angry at God, that would mean I believed there was Someone to be angry at. But I did not feel anger when people prayed. I felt distance. Like I was watching everyone speak a language I had been taught to repeat but never truly understood.

I went downstairs.

My mother was fixing Jenna's hair near the hallway mirror. Jenna stood very still, holding a small pink bag in both hands. She looked serious in the way little children look serious when they know adults expect them to behave.

"There you are," my mother said, glancing at me through the mirror.
"You look handsome."

I shrugged.

She smiled anyway.

My father looked at me from the doorway.

"Tuck in your shirt properly."

I looked down. One side had come loose.

I tucked it in.

"And stand straight."

I stood straighter.

He shook his head. Not enough for anyone to call it anger, but enough for me to see disappointment starting early.

My mother noticed. She always noticed more than she said.

"Leave him," she said softly. "He's ready."

My father did not answer her. He only looked at his watch again.

Jenna looked at me through the mirror and smiled. It was small and nervous, like she was trying to remind me that the day could still be normal if I let it.

I almost smiled back.

Almost.

But my father opened the front door, and the morning light spilled into the hallway.

"Let's go," he said.

The drive to church was quiet, except for the worship music playing softly on the radio. My mother hummed along under her breath. Jenna tapped her fingers against her little bag in time with the song. My father drove with both hands on the wheel, his eyes fixed ahead.

I sat in the back seat beside Jenna and watched buildings slide past the window.

People were walking in groups, dressed neatly and carrying Bibles. Some smiled as they greeted each other. Some held the hands of children who looked just as polished and uncomfortable as I felt. Everyone looked clean. Everyone looked certain.

I wondered if any of them were pretending too.

Then I hated myself for wondering.

Because in my house, questions were not always questions.

Sometimes they were disrespect.

Sometimes they were pride.

Sometimes they were proof that something was wrong with you.

Jenna leaned closer to me and whispered, "Are you okay?"

I kept looking out of the window.

"Yeah."

"You look angry."

"I always look angry."

She smiled a little. "True."

I should have laughed. The old me would have. The version of me who used to put toy cars on his head and make her laugh until she rolled onto the floor would have turned it into a joke. But that version of me felt far away now.

So I only said, "Face front before Dad complains."

She sat back immediately.

That was what our house did to people.

It made even small things feel like warnings.

The church building came into view, tall and bright under the morning sun. Cars filled the parking area. People stood outside, shaking hands and laughing softly. Everyone looked like they knew how to belong there.

Inside, the church was warm and crowded. Sunlight came through the tall windows in pale yellow strips, landing across people's shoulders, hats, hymn books, and polished shoes. The air smelled like perfume, wood polish, and the faint dust of old carpet.

We sat near the middle.

My father took the end of the pew, as he always did. My mother sat beside him, then Jenna, then me. I wanted the aisle seat, the one nearest the exit, but my father always took it. He liked being the first to stand, the first to leave, the first to be seen.

The choir was already singing.

Their voices rose together, filling the room until the sound seemed to press against my chest. People clapped. Some raised their hands. Some closed their eyes. Some whispered words I could not hear.

My mother sang softly beside me, one hand resting over her chest like she was holding something precious there. Her face looked peaceful. Not fake peaceful. Real peaceful. The kind of peace that made me angry because I did not know how to reach it.

Jenna copied her.

She stood carefully, glancing up every few seconds to make sure she was doing it right. When my mother lifted her hand, Jenna lifted hers too. When my mother closed her eyes, Jenna squeezed hers shut so tightly that her forehead wrinkled.

My father did not sing loudly, but he looked focused. Even in worship, his jaw stayed tight, like faith was another thing that needed discipline.

I stood between them all, mouthing words I did not believe.

I knew the song. I knew when the chorus came. I knew when people would clap. I knew when somebody would shout "Amen" from the back. I knew the movements, the sounds, the rhythm of it all.

But knowing the movements was not the same as believing them.

The song rose higher.

Someone shouted, "Amen!"

I lowered my head because everyone else did.

I closed my eyes because everyone else did.

But behind my eyelids, there was nothing.

No peace.

No voice.

No light.

No warm feeling in my chest.

Just darkness and the sound of my own breathing.

I tried, at first.

That is the part people never believed about me. They thought I wanted to be difficult. They thought I enjoyed disagreeing just to annoy them. Maybe sometimes I did. Maybe I had learned to enjoy the reaction because reactions were easier to understand than silence.

But that morning, I tried.

I squeezed my eyes shut.

I listened to the words of the song.

I waited for something to happen inside me.

Nothing did.

The song ended, and everyone sat down. The pastor walked to the pulpit after the choir finished. He was tall, with a calm voice and a smile that made adults nod before he even spoke. He opened his Bible slowly, like every movement mattered.

"Today," he said, "we are talking about obedience."

My father shifted slightly beside me.

I knew that word was going to find me.

"Obedience is not only about following rules when we understand them," the pastor continued. "Obedience is trusting even when we do not understand."

People nodded.

My mother whispered, "Amen."

I stared at the floor.

The pastor's voice filled the room, but the words felt like they were sliding past me. Trust. Faith. Submission. Purpose. Sin. Forgiveness.

Everyone else seemed to know what those words meant.

To me, they felt like locked doors.

The pastor told a story about a boy who ignored his father's warning and suffered because of it. The church listened carefully. Some people laughed at the lighter parts. Some shook their heads at the serious parts.

I knew what the story was supposed to mean.

Children should listen.

Parents know better.

Doubt is dangerous.

Pride destroys.

It was always the same message wearing different clothes.

Then the pastor said something that made the whole church laugh gently.

"Some young people think they know everything."

A few adults turned their heads and smiled at their children.

My mother nudged me lightly with her elbow, like it was a harmless joke.

My father did not smile.

I felt heat rise in my face.

The pastor went on.

"They ask questions. They challenge everything. They want proof for what must be believed by faith."

I looked up.

For the first time that morning, I was listening properly.

"What they do not understand," he said, "is that doubt can become pride if the heart refuses to bow."

Pride.

That word sat beside obedience and waited for me.

I did not know if I was proud. I did not feel proud. Proud people seemed tall and sure. I felt small and confused and tired of being told that questions made me wrong.

But the pastor kept speaking as if doubt was always a choice. As if belief was something you could switch on because someone older told you to. As if the emptiness inside me was not emptiness, but rebellion.

I looked at my mother.

Her eyes were closed again. Her lips moved silently. She looked peaceful in a way I had never understood. I wanted to ask her how she did it. I wanted to ask if she had ever doubted. I wanted to ask if she had ever sat in church and felt alone in a crowd of people singing about love.

But I knew better.

Questions like that could hurt people.

And I was already good at hurting people.

I looked at Jenna.

She was listening with her whole face. Her hands were folded neatly in her lap. Her little pink bag sat beside her like it was also trying to behave. She believed because she was young enough to trust what she was given.

I wondered when that would end.

I wondered if one day she would sit where I sat, surrounded by songs and prayers, and feel nothing too.

The thought made something twist inside me.

After the sermon, the pastor asked everyone to bow their heads.

"We will pray together," he said.

The church became quiet.

Not silent, exactly. There were still coughs, shifting feet, babies crying softly, and the hum of fans above us. But the room changed. People lowered themselves into seriousness.

I bowed my head.

Again.

The pastor prayed first.

His voice moved slowly, carefully, filling the spaces between people.

Then he asked families to pray together.

My mother reached for my hand.

I let her take it.

Her palm was warm.

Jenna held my other hand. Hers was smaller and slightly sweaty. She squeezed my fingers once, smiling like this was something beautiful.

I wanted it to be beautiful.

I really did.

Then my father spoke.

"Marshall," he said quietly.

I opened one eye.

He was looking at me.

"Lead the prayer."

My stomach tightened.

"What?"

"Lead the prayer," he repeated. "For the family."

My mother glanced at him.

"Maybe not now," she said softly.

"He is old enough," my father said.

Jenna looked at me with wide eyes.

I stared at the floor.

The family in front of us had already started praying. Behind us, someone was whispering, "Lord, guide us." All around me, voices rose and fell like water.

But inside my head, everything became loud.

I did not know what to say.

Not because I did not know prayer words. I had heard them all my life.

Thank you, Lord.

Bless us.

Protect us.

Forgive us.

Guide us.

I could have copied them.

That would have been easy.

But suddenly, copying felt impossible.

My father's eyes were on me.

"Marshall," he warned.

I swallowed.

"I can't."

His face tightened.

"You can."

"No, I can't."

My mother squeezed my hand gently.

"Just say something small," she whispered.

Something small.

A lie could be small.

A lie could be quiet.

A lie could keep everyone happy.

I opened my mouth.

Nothing came out.

My father leaned closer.

"Do not embarrass me here."

That was when something inside me snapped.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

Just a thin, tired string breaking.

"I don't believe in it," I whispered.

My mother's hand went still.

Jenna stopped squeezing my fingers.

My father stared at me.

"What did you say?"

I should have stopped.

I should have looked down and muttered something safe. I should have said I was confused, or tired, or sorry. I should have become the boy they needed for one more morning.

But I was tired of pretending.

I looked at him.

"I said I don't believe in it."

His voice dropped lower.

"In what?"

I felt everyone around us still praying, still whispering, still reaching for something I could not feel.

I said it before fear could swallow it.

"God."

The word seemed too small for how much damage it did.

My mother's face changed first.

Not anger.

Hurt.

Deep, quiet hurt, as if I had taken something precious from her and crushed it in my hand.

Jenna looked confused.

My father looked like I had slapped him.

For a moment, nobody spoke.

Then he stood up.

"Outside."

My mother whispered, "Please, not here."

"Outside," he repeated.

I followed him out of the pew.

Every step felt loud, even though the church was still praying. I could feel people noticing us. A woman near the aisle opened one eye. A boy from my Sunday class stared at me like I had become something dangerous.

Outside, the sunlight was too bright.

The church doors closed behind us, muffling the prayers inside.

My father turned to me.

"Say that again."

I looked at the ground.

"Say it."

"I don't believe in God."

His jaw moved.

"And you thought church was the place to display your foolishness?"

"You asked me to pray."

"So you disrespect your family?"

"I'm not disrespecting anyone."

"You call God a lie in His own house and say you are not disrespecting anyone?"

"I didn't call Him a lie."

"You said you don't believe."

"Because I don't."

The words came out stronger than I felt.

My father stepped closer.

I did not move, but my body prepared itself. My shoulders tightened.
My hands curled. My face waited.

But he did not hit me.

Not there.

Maybe because we were outside church. Maybe because someone could
see. Maybe because even he knew some things looked worse in sunlight.

Instead, he pointed at me.

"You are not clever," he said. "Do not mistake rebellion for
intelligence."

I laughed once.

It was a mistake.

His eyes hardened.

"You find this funny?"

"No."

"You always laugh when you should be ashamed."

I looked away.

There it was again.

Shame.

The old language of my house.

My mother came outside with Jenna a few minutes later. Her face was calm, but her eyes were wet. Jenna held her little bag close to her chest and looked between us like she was trying to understand which side of the world had broken.

The rest of the service continued inside without us.

No one spoke on the drive home.

That silence was worse than shouting.

My father drove with both hands on the wheel, staring straight ahead. My mother looked out of the window. Jenna sat beside me in the back seat, pressing her knees together, her small shoes tapping nervously against the floor.

Once, she whispered, "Marshall?"

I did not answer.

Not because I wanted to hurt her.

Because if I turned to her, I might see fear in her face.

And I was tired of being the reason people looked afraid.

At home, my father told Jenna to go to her room.

She obeyed immediately.

Then he turned to me.

"You will not bring this nonsense into my house."

I stood in the living room with my hands at my sides.

"It's not nonsense."

My mother looked at me quickly, warning me to stop.

But I did not.

Maybe I wanted the fight.

Maybe anger felt easier than fear.

Maybe I wanted them to hurt because I felt hurt too.

"I just don't believe," I said. "Why is that so hard for you to understand?"

My father laughed, but there was no humour in it.

"Because children do not know anything and still think they have discovered the world."

"I'm not a child."

"You are exactly a child."

"Then stop asking me to act like I know what I believe."

My mother covered her mouth.

My father moved closer.

"You think faith is a game? You think your mother prays for this family because she is stupid?"

"I didn't say that."

"You think I raised you so you could stand in church and shame us?"

"There it is," I said.

His eyes narrowed.

"What?"

"Shame. That's all you care about."

The room went still.

I had said something true.

That made it dangerous.

My father's hand came fast.

The sound cracked through the living room.

My head turned with it.

My cheek burned.

My mother cried out.

Jenna's door opened slightly upstairs, then closed again.

I stayed where I was.

I did not cry.

I did not apologize.

I only smiled.

Slowly.

Ugly.

My father looked almost more angry because of it.

"You think smiling makes you strong?"

I said nothing.

Because the truth was, no.

It did not make me strong.

It only kept me from breaking in front of him.

My mother stepped between us.

"Enough," she said, her voice shaking.

My father pointed toward the stairs.

"Go to your room."

I went.

Not because I respected him.

Because I had nowhere else to go.

In my room, I sat on the edge of my bed and stared at the wall. The church song was still stuck in my head, soft and annoying. My cheek pulsed with heat. My chest felt hollow.

I had expected to feel free after saying it.

I don't believe in God.

But I did not feel free.

I felt cut loose.

Like everyone else had been holding onto a rope, and I had finally admitted my hands were empty.

For the first time, I wondered what happened when people died.

Not in the church way.

Not heaven, not hell, not angels, not judgement.

Just nothing.

A light turning off.

A voice stopping mid-sentence.

A body becoming a thing people cried over.

The thought should have scared me.

It did, a little.

But there was also something coldly comforting about it.

If there was nothing after death, then maybe nothing really mattered.

Not prayers.

Not grades.

Not my father's disappointment.

Not Ms. Carter's warnings.

Not Daniel's red ears.

Not my mother's tears.

Nothing.

I held onto that thought because it felt like armour.

If nothing mattered, then nobody could guilt me.

If nothing mattered, then shame was pointless.

If nothing mattered, then I could stop trying to be good for people who were never satisfied anyway.

Downstairs, I heard my mother crying quietly.

For a second, I almost got up.

Almost.

I imagined walking down the stairs, standing in the doorway, and saying something soft. Something that would fix at least one part of the damage.

I'm sorry.

I didn't mean to hurt you.

I just don't know how to believe.

But the words stayed inside me.

Because apologizing felt too much like surrender.

And I had already lost too much that day.

So I stayed on the bed.

I told myself I did not care.

I told myself I was right.

I told myself they were all scared of questions because questions made their world weak.

But deep down, under the anger, under the pride, under the empty room and the burning cheek, something smaller whispered the truth.

I did not stop pretending because I was brave.

I stopped pretending because I was tired.

The memory faded slowly.

The church walls dissolved first. Then the pews, the choir, the sunlight, my mother's warm hand, Jenna's small fingers, my father's hard voice.

But the emptiness stayed.

It followed me into the next memory.

And before that next memory began, I understood one thing.

That day, I did not lose God.

I lost the last place where my family thought I still belonged.

Chapter 5 — Minute Four

By the time I was thirteen, I had learned that adults could lie better than children.

Children lied badly. We left crumbs on our mouths, homework in our bags, guilt in our eyes. Adults lied differently. They stood tall while doing it. They wore clean shirts. They quoted Bible verses. They called themselves responsible. They spoke about discipline, respect, and honesty as if saying the words often enough made them true.

My father was the best liar I knew.

The memory opened at night.

Rain tapped against my bedroom window, soft at first, then harder, like fingers asking to be let in. My room was dark except for the weak yellow light from my desk lamp. It made everything look tired: my schoolbag half-open on the floor, my uniform hanging over the chair, my notebooks stacked in a corner like evidence against me.

On my desk was my report card.

I did not need to look at it again.

I already knew what it said.

Mathematics: 38%.

Science: 41%.

English: 52%.

Teacher's comment: *Marshall is capable, but he lacks focus and effort.*

Capable.

Adults loved that word.

They used it when they wanted you to feel guilty for not becoming the person they had imagined. It was worse than being called stupid. If I was stupid, then maybe none of it was my fault. But capable meant I had failed on purpose. Capable meant I had been given something valuable and had chosen to waste it.

My father had read the report first.

He had stood in the living room with the paper in his hand, reading each grade slowly, like he wanted every number to bruise me before the next one arrived.

"Thirty-eight," he said.

I stared at the floor.

"Forty-one."

My mother sat on the sofa, silent.

"Fifty-two."

Jenna stood near the hallway, pretending not to listen.

My father lowered the paper.

"Is this funny to you?"

I said nothing.

"Answer me."

"No."

"No, what?"

"No, sir."

He stepped closer.

"So why do you behave like your future is a joke?"

I wanted to tell him I did not know.

I wanted to tell him that every time I tried to study, the words moved around in my head until I felt stupid. I wanted to tell him that asking for help felt like handing someone a weapon. I wanted to tell him that I was

tired of everyone expecting something from me when I could barely stand being myself.

Instead, I shrugged.

That was my mistake.

His face changed.

Not suddenly. Slowly. Like a door closing.

"You think this attitude makes you strong?" he asked. "You think pretending not to care will save you?"

I looked away.

He moved closer, and my body remembered fear before my mind did.

"You are becoming useless, Marshall."

The word sank deep.

Useless.

I could handle insults from classmates. I could handle teachers writing comments in red pen. I could even handle Justin and Caleb laughing at how badly we had failed.

But from him, the word felt different.

It felt final.

Later, when I was sent to my room, I slammed the door hard enough to make the walls shake.

Then I waited.

I waited for someone to come after me.

My mother, maybe.

Jenna.

Anyone.

Nobody came.

So I sat in the quiet room with my report card on the desk and my father's voice still moving around inside my head.

Useless.

I laughed once.

It sounded wrong.

There was nobody there to laugh with me. Nobody to impress. Nobody to trick into thinking I did not care. Without an audience, the laugh fell flat and disappeared.

That was the thing about being alone.

You had no one to perform for.

I stood up and paced the room. Three steps to the wardrobe. Three steps back to the bed. Three steps to the desk. Three steps back again.

My thoughts would not slow down.

They came all at once.

My grades.

My father's face.

My mother's silence.

Jenna watching from the hallway.

Ms. Carter's voice from years ago.

No, Marshall. It was a choice.

I hated that word.

Choice.

It made everything my fault.

Before I could think about it anymore, something crashed downstairs.

I froze.

At first, I thought it was thunder. Then another sound followed it — glass against the floor, sharp and ugly.

Then my mother's voice.

"You said you stopped."

The room went still around me.

I moved toward my door and opened it just enough to see the hallway. The light from downstairs stretched across the floorboards in a thin yellow line.

My father's voice came next.

"Don't start."

His words were heavy, blurred at the edges.

He had been drinking again.

I knew the sound of it. The slow steps. The careless slam of keys on the table. The way his voice became both louder and weaker, as if anger was the only thing holding him upright.

My mother said something I could not hear.

Then my father laughed.

Not a happy laugh.

A mean one.

"You went through my phone?"

My hand tightened around the door handle.

For a second, I forgot about my report card. I forgot about school, Ms. Carter, Daniel, Justin, Caleb, all of it. The whole world shrank to the hallway and the voices rising from downstairs.

"I saw the messages," my mother said. "Don't lie to me."

Silence.

Then my father said, "You don't know what you saw."

"I know exactly what I saw."

Another glass sound.

This time louder.

I stepped into the hallway.

Jenna's door was open too.

She stood there in her pajamas, holding a teddy bear against her chest. Her eyes were wide and wet.

"Marshall," she whispered.

I put a finger to my lips.

Downstairs, my father's voice rose.

"You think you can question me in my own house?"

My mother's voice shook, but she did not back down.

"You come home drunk, you shout at the children, you shame everyone, and now this?"

"This?" he repeated, like the word offended him.

"The woman, David. The messages. The calls. Do you think I'm stupid?"

For a moment, nothing moved.

Then something broke.

Not glass this time.

Something heavier.

Jenna flinched.

I moved without thinking and stood in front of her, as if my body could block the sound.

That was the thing about fear in our house. It travelled. It climbed stairs. It slipped under doors. It touched everyone.

My father started shouting then. Not words at first, just anger wearing a voice. He called my mother ungrateful. Paranoid. Dramatic. He said she was the reason the house had no peace. He said she was poisoning the children against him.

That was when I understood something that made my stomach turn.

He was not sorry.

Not even a little.

This was the same man who slapped me for not reading a word. The same man who said nobody respected a fool. The same man who dragged me to church and told me doubt was shameful. The same man who acted like discipline made him holy.

And there he was.

Drunk.

Lying.

Cheating.

Still speaking like he was the victim.

I looked at Jenna. She was crying silently, pressing the teddy bear so hard against her chest that its face was crushed.

"Go back inside," I whispered.

She shook her head.

"Please," I said.

She stepped back into her room and closed the door, but not fully. A thin line of light stayed between the door and the frame.

I walked down two steps.

Then three.

I do not know what I planned to do. Maybe nothing. Maybe I wanted to see his face. Maybe I wanted to catch him being exactly what he was so I could stop wondering if I was the problem.

From the staircase, I saw them.

My mother stood near the dining table, one hand gripping the back of a chair. Her eyes were red, but she was not crying anymore. My father stood

opposite her, his shirt untucked, his tie hanging loose, his face shiny with sweat and anger.

On the floor near his foot was a broken cup.

My mother saw me first.

"Marshall," she said softly. "Go upstairs."

My father turned.

His eyes narrowed.

"What are you doing there?"

I should have gone back.

I did not.

"You're drunk," I said.

The room went silent.

My mother's face changed.

"Marshall, please."

My father stared at me.

Then he smiled.

It was the same kind of smile I would later use on other people. Sharp. Empty. Built to hurt.

"So now you are the man of the house?"

I looked at the broken cup.

"No," I said. "I just thought men of the house were supposed to know how to stand properly."

My mother whispered my name like a warning.

My father moved toward the stairs.

Slowly.

Each step made my body colder.

"You think you're funny?"

I wanted to stop. I really did.

But anger had already taken over. Anger felt better than fear. Anger made me feel taller, even when my legs were shaking.

"You always say I embarrass you," I said. "But look at you."

His face changed.

That was when I knew I had gone too far.

He climbed the stairs faster.

I backed up, but not quickly enough.

His hand caught the front of my shirt and shoved me against the wall. The air jumped out of my chest. I heard my mother shout. I heard Jenna's door open again.

My father's breath smelled bitter.

"You will not disrespect me," he said.

I looked at him, my heart beating so hard it hurt.

For one second, I saw him clearly.

Not as a father.

Not as a judge.

Just a man.

A weak, angry, lying man who needed everyone else to feel small so he could feel powerful.

Maybe that should have made me pity him.

It did not.

It made me hate him.

He let go of my shirt with a shove, and I stumbled backward. My shoulder hit the wall.

He pointed upstairs.

"Go to your room."

This time, I went.

Not because I respected him.

Because if I stayed, something worse would happen.

I closed my door and stood in the middle of my room, breathing hard.

My hands were shaking.

My chest hurt.

My thoughts were too loud.

He drinks.

He lies.

He cheats.

He hits.

And somehow I am the problem.

I looked at the family photo on my desk.

It was old. From a holiday I barely remembered. My mother was smiling. Jenna was missing one tooth. My father had one hand on my shoulder, looking proud enough to fool anyone.

I picked it up.

For a moment, I stared at his face behind the glass.

Clean shirt.

Straight posture.

Perfect father.

Perfect lie.

Then I threw it.

The frame hit the wall and cracked open on the floor.

The sound was sharp enough to make me freeze.

For a few seconds, I only stood there, listening.

No one came.

Of course no one came.

I crouched down and started picking up the pieces before anyone could see. My fingers moved too quickly. I was not being careful. I was angry, and anger made everything feel urgent.

Then pain flashed across my hand.

Small.

Sudden.

Real.

I pulled back and stared.

The pain should have scared me.

It did, at first.

But something else happened too.

For one second, every thought in my head stopped.

My father's voice disappeared.

My mother's crying disappeared.

Jenna's fear disappeared.

The messages, the shouting, the broken cup, the report card, the word *useless* — all of it went quiet.

There was only the sting.

Only my breathing.

Only the rain against the window.

I sat there on the floor, confused by the silence inside me.

It did not feel good.

Not really.

It felt dangerous.

But it was quiet.

And because I was thirteen, angry, ashamed, and tired of feeling powerless, I confused quiet with peace.

I wrapped my hand quickly and shoved the broken frame into the bin. My heart was still beating too fast. I kept looking at the door, expecting someone to come in and ask what had happened.

Nobody did.

I sat on the floor beside my bed until the rain softened.

The room smelled like dust and old paper. The lamp buzzed quietly. My report card still lay on the desk, folded and ugly.

I picked it up.

The teacher's comment stared back at me.

Marshall is capable, but he lacks focus and effort.

I read it again and again until the words stopped meaning anything.

Then I laughed.

Not loudly.

Not like in class.

Just enough to prove I was still me.

But I was not still me.

Something had shifted.

That night, I learned another wrong lesson.

I learned that pain outside the body could distract from pain inside the mind.

I learned that silence could be mistaken for control.

I learned that when nobody hears you, you might start hurting yourself just to feel real.

The memory faded slowly.

The rain disappeared first. Then the desk lamp. Then the cracked picture frame. Then the family photo, with all of us smiling like we had been happy.

But the feeling stayed.

The shame.

The anger.

The dangerous quiet.

And before the next memory began, I understood something I had refused to understand for years.

I was not only hurting other people.

I was hurting myself too.

Chapter 6 — Minute Five

By the time I was fourteen, failing had become easier when I did it loudly.

Quiet failure was humiliating.

Quiet failure meant sitting at your desk with your test paper turned upside down, praying nobody asked what you got. It meant blinking too fast when the teacher walked past. It meant folding your report card small enough to hide in your pocket. It meant feeling your stomach drop before your father even saw the grade.

I hated quiet failure.

So I made mine loud.

If I failed, I laughed first.

If I did not understand the lesson, I disturbed it.

If the work looked difficult, I called it useless.

If someone tried hard, I mocked them before they could remind me of everything I was not.

That was how I survived school.

Not well.

But loudly.

The memory opened in a Mathematics classroom.

The room smelled like whiteboard markers, sweat, and the packed lunches people had already started opening even though break was still twenty minutes away. The fan above us turned slowly, making a tired clicking sound every few seconds. At the front of the room, Mr. Harris stood by the board, explaining equations like they were supposed to make sense.

I sat at the back with Justin and Caleb.

Of course I did.

By then, the back row had become our kingdom. It was where we whispered, laughed, copied homework, threw paper balls, and acted like we were above everything happening in front of us.

Mr. Harris wrote a question on the board.

"Who can solve this?"

Nobody in our row moved.

I stared at the numbers, pretending they were boring instead of terrifying.

The truth was, I did not understand them. I had missed the beginning of the topic because I had spent most of the lesson making Justin laugh. Then I missed the next part because I was too lost to catch up. After that, I stopped trying completely.

That was the easiest part.

Once you missed enough, giving up felt like a decision you had made on purpose.

Justin leaned toward me.

"Bro, what language is that?"

I smirked.

"Ancient suffering."

Caleb snorted.

Mr. Harris turned around.

"Something funny at the back?"

The class looked at us.

That used to scare me.

Now I knew what to do with it.

I leaned back in my chair and shrugged.

"Sir, I'm just wondering when we'll use this in real life."

A few students laughed.

Mr. Harris sighed.

"You might use it if you pay attention long enough to understand it."

"Ouch," Justin whispered.

I placed a hand on my chest like I had been wounded.

The class laughed again.

Mr. Harris looked tired.

Not angry.

Tired.

That was worse sometimes. Angry teachers still believed they could change you. Tired teachers had started giving up.

"Open your books," he said. "Question four."

I opened my book.

The page was mostly blank.

There were a few numbers from the start of the lesson, a drawing of Mr. Harris with a giant head, and a sentence Justin had written when I was not looking.

Marshall is allergic to success.

I laughed when I saw it.

Not because it was funny.

Because it was too close to the truth.

Mr. Harris walked around the room, checking people's work. I bent over my page and pretended to write. My pen moved, but it did not form numbers. It made lines, circles, meaningless scratches.

Beside me, Justin had written nothing.

Caleb had copied the question wrong.

We were all failing.

That made it feel less lonely.

When Mr. Harris reached our row, he stopped beside my desk.

"Marshall."

I looked up.

"Yes, sir?"

"Where is your working?"

I looked down at the page as if it might have appeared by itself.

"I was thinking."

Justin coughed into his fist to hide a laugh.

Mr. Harris did not smile.

"Thinking is useful when it leads somewhere."

I shrugged.

"Maybe mine is taking the scenic route."

More laughter.

Mr. Harris took my book from the desk and looked at it. His eyes moved across the blank spaces, the drawing, and the useless scribbles.

For a moment, he said nothing.

That silence reminded me of Ms. Carter.

It made something uncomfortable move inside my chest.

Then he placed the book back down.

"You are wasting your ability," he said quietly.

There it was again.

The old word in a different form.

Capable.

Ability.

Potential.

Adults kept seeing something in me that I could not reach, then blaming me for not becoming it.

I smiled.

"Maybe my ability is hiding, sir."

Justin laughed loudly.

Caleb slapped the desk.

Mr. Harris looked at me for a long second.

"No," he said. "You are hiding."

The laughter around me thinned.

I looked away.

For a moment, the classroom felt too bright.

Mr. Harris moved on.

I picked up my pen and stared at the blank page.

You are hiding.

I hated how close he had come.

So I did what I always did.

I turned to Justin and whispered, "Sir thinks he's a therapist now."

Justin laughed.

The feeling disappeared.

Or at least, I buried it deep enough to pretend it had.

At break time, test papers were returned.

That was always the worst part of the week.

Mr. Harris walked around with a pile of papers, placing them face down on each desk. Some students flipped theirs over quickly. Others waited. Some smiled. Some swallowed hard. Some tried to hide the red marks with their hands.

I already knew mine would be bad.

I could feel it before I saw it.

When Mr. Harris placed the paper on my desk, he paused.

"Marshall," he said, "you need to start taking this seriously."

I gave him a lazy smile.

"Yes, sir. I'll start tomorrow."

Justin laughed.

Mr. Harris walked away.

I flipped the paper.

34%.

For a second, the number was all I could see.

Red.

Ugly.

Final.

Thirty-four.

Lower than last time.

Lower than I wanted to admit.

My throat tightened.

Then Justin leaned over.

"What did you get?"

I held it up like a trophy.

"Academic excellence."

Justin burst out laughing.

Caleb grabbed his own paper and waved it in the air.

"Twenty-nine! I'm basically a genius."

The boys around us laughed.

So I laughed too.

I laughed like the number did not matter. Like I had chosen it. Like failure was just another joke I was telling before anyone else could.

But inside, something sank.

I imagined my father seeing it.

I imagined his face closing.

I imagined his voice.

Useless.

I folded the paper quickly and pushed it into my bag.

Justin saw me do it.

For one second, his smile faded.

Then he looked away.

That was the rule between us. We could laugh about failing, but we could not admit it hurt.

Because if one of us admitted it, the whole performance would collapse.

That evening, before I even reached home, I already knew the grade would not stay hidden forever.

It never did.

My father had a way of finding failure. It was like he could smell it on me before I opened my bag.

At dinner, I barely touched my food. My mother asked if I was feeling sick, and I said no. Jenna looked at me from across the table, then looked away. She had become good at knowing when not to ask questions.

My father's phone buzzed beside his plate.

He picked it up, glanced at the screen, and smiled.

Not at me.

Never at me.

"At least someone in this family understands discipline," he said.

I already knew who he meant before he said the name.

Aaron.

My cousin Aaron had passed all his exams that term. Everyone knew because my father mentioned it like breaking news every chance he got. Aaron studied early. Aaron helped at home. Aaron respected adults. Aaron knew where he was going in life.

Aaron was everything I was not.

My father turned the phone so my mother could see the message.

"Your sister says Aaron got top marks again."

My mother gave a small smile.

"That's good for him."

My father looked at me.

"You hear that, Marshall? Top marks."

I pushed food around my plate.

"Yes, sir."

"Aaron is not older than you by much, but look at the difference."

I said nothing.

"He studies. He respects his future. He does not sit around acting like the world is a joke."

My hand tightened around my fork.

Jenna looked down at her plate.

My father leaned back in his chair.

"Maybe you should spend more time with him. Learn something useful."

I smiled.

That was automatic by then.

"Maybe Aaron can teach me how to be perfect."

My mother's eyes flashed toward me.

A warning.

My father's face hardened.

"This is your problem. Everything is a joke."

I wanted to tell him that the joke was the only thing keeping me from breaking.

I wanted to tell him that every time he said Aaron's name, it felt like he was holding up a mirror just to show me how wrong I looked.

Instead, I shrugged.

"Good for Aaron."

My father stared at me.

"You are not ashamed?"

I looked up.

There was the word again.

Shame.

Always waiting.

Always hungry.

I smiled wider.

"No, sir."

That was a lie.

I was ashamed of the test paper in my bag. I was ashamed of the blank spaces in my exercise book. I was ashamed that Mr. Harris could see I was hiding. I was ashamed that Aaron could do so easily what felt impossible for me.

But I had learned a long time ago that shame was safer when it looked like arrogance.

So I wore arrogance like armour.

The next day at school, I was louder than usual.

That was how it worked. The worse home became, the louder I became outside it.

After break, we had English.

The class was supposed to be reading silently, but silence never lasted long near us.

Justin had his phone hidden under the desk. Caleb leaned in close, pretending to look at his book. I glanced at the teacher, then back at them.

"What are you watching?" I whispered.

Justin grinned.

"Something you're too innocent for."

I rolled my eyes.

"Me? Innocent?"

He turned the screen slightly.

I saw enough to understand what it was.

One of those videos boys whispered about like it made them older. The kind of thing passed around in secret, laughed about loudly, then hidden quickly when an adult walked near.

I looked away fast.

Not because I was innocent.

Because for a second, I felt uncomfortable.

Justin noticed.

"Why are you acting shy?" he whispered.

Caleb laughed under his breath.

I forced a smile.

"I'm not shy. It's just boring."

"Boring?" Justin whispered. "You're lying."

He showed Caleb, and Caleb laughed because Justin laughed.

Then they started talking.

Not loudly enough for the whole class to hear, but loudly enough for me.

They talked about girls like girls were not people sitting in the same room as us. They talked like appearances were scores. Like bodies were jokes. Like being rude made them grown.

At first, I stayed quiet.

Then Justin nudged me.

"Marshall, what do you think?"

I looked across the room.

A girl named Sophie was sitting two rows ahead, writing neatly in her book. She had done nothing. She was just there, existing quietly, probably trying to finish the work.

Justin nodded toward her and made a comment about how she looked.

Caleb laughed immediately.

I laughed too.

Not because it was funny.

Because silence would have made me look different from them.

Sophie heard us.

I knew she did because her shoulders tightened. Her pen stopped moving. She did not turn around, but her whole body changed, like she had suddenly become aware of herself in a way she had not asked for.

For one second, something twisted in my stomach.

I knew that feeling.

I knew what it was like to become smaller because someone else had decided to make you a joke.

But Justin was still laughing.

Caleb was still watching me.

So I buried the feeling.

I leaned back and said something worse.

The boys laughed harder.

Sophie kept her head down.

That should have been the moment I stopped.

It was not.

That was the problem with us. We always pushed one step further than necessary. A joke was never enough. We needed a reaction. We needed someone embarrassed. We needed proof that we had power.

After class, Sophie walked past our desk with her books held tightly against her chest.

Justin whispered something.

Caleb laughed.

I smirked, but I did not say anything.

Sophie's eyes flicked toward me for half a second.

Not angry.

Not even surprised.

Just disappointed.

I hated that look.

Anger was easier. Fear was easier. Even hatred was easier.

Disappointment made me feel like there was still a version of me she had expected to be better.

I looked away first.

At lunch, we sat near the edge of the courtyard, where teachers did not usually bother us. Justin was still talking about the video. Caleb kept laughing and asking stupid questions. I listened, laughed when I was supposed to, and pretended I understood more than I did.

That was another kind of pretending.

Pretending to be older.

Pretending to be confident.

Pretending that disrespect was the same as maturity.

The truth was, most of us did not know what we were doing. We were children trying to sound like men. We repeated things we had seen, heard, or watched, then acted like it made us powerful.

But it did not make us powerful.

It made us emptier.

I did not know that then.

Or maybe I did.

Maybe I knew and chose not to care.

Justin threw a chip at me.

"You're quiet today."

"I'm thinking about my future," I said.

Caleb laughed. "Your future is prison."

"Still better than Maths class."

Justin nearly choked on his drink.

I smiled.

There it was again.

The easy feeling.

The warmth of being funny.

The safety of making other people laugh before they could look too closely at me.

Then I saw Daniel across the courtyard.

He was sitting under a tree with two other students, reading something from a notebook. He looked calm. Focused. Like school was not attacking him from every direction.

For a moment, I wondered what that felt like.

To understand the work.

To care without being ashamed of caring.

To try without feeling like failure would destroy you.

Then Daniel looked up.

Our eyes met.

His face changed slightly.

Not fear.

Memory.

He remembered me.

The teacher's pet joke. The playground. The way I had made him smaller because I could.

I looked away.

Justin followed my eyes.

"Isn't that the mouse from primary?"

I shrugged.

"Something like that."

"You still talk to him?"

"Why would I?"

Justin laughed.

But I did not feel as proud as I expected to.

The rest of the day dragged.

In Science, I forgot my textbook.

That was not unusual.

Mrs. Allen was teaching about the brain that day. She had drawn a rough diagram on the board, with labels pointing to different parts I was supposed to remember. I did not write any of them down. Justin was drawing flames around the title in his book, and Caleb was trying to balance a pen on his upper lip.

Thomas was sitting two rows ahead.

I barely noticed him then.

He was quiet, as usual, his back straight, his pen moving carefully across the page. He always wrote like the words mattered.

Mrs. Allen tapped the board.

"The brain is not only responsible for thinking," she said. "It is also connected to memory, emotion, fear, and survival."

Justin leaned toward me.

"My brain is responsible for sleeping."

Caleb laughed under his breath.

I smiled.

Mrs. Allen turned around.

"There's an idea," she continued, "that in the final moments before death, the brain may replay important memories. Not random memories, but the ones connected to fear, love, regret, or unfinished emotion."

The class became more interested then.

Death always made people listen.

Someone near the front raised a hand.

"How long?"

Mrs. Allen paused.

"Some people say minutes," she replied. "Seven minutes is one version of the idea."

Justin snorted.

"Seven minutes? That's not even enough time to explain my homework excuses."

Caleb laughed.

I laughed too.

"If my life flashes before my eyes," I said, leaning back in my chair, "I hope it skips school."

A few people laughed.

Thomas did not.

He kept his eyes on his notebook, but I saw his pen stop moving.

Mrs. Allen looked at me for a moment.

"Sometimes," she said, "the memories we want to skip are the ones we need to face."

I looked away.

Back then, I thought she was just trying to sound deep.

I did not know my brain was already saving the worst parts for later.

In History, I got sent out for talking.

In Mathematics, Mr. Harris collected the homework I had not done.

Every lesson became another place to perform. Another place to avoid being exposed. Another place to laugh before someone could ask me why I was falling behind.

By the final period, I was tired.

Not the kind of tired sleep could fix.

The kind that sat behind your eyes and made every sound too loud.

The teacher was explaining something at the front, but I was not listening. Justin was drawing on the desk. Caleb was trying to balance a ruler on his nose. I stared at my folded test paper sticking out of my bag.

34%.

The number waited for me.

I imagined taking it home.

I imagined my father.

I imagined Aaron's name being brought up again and again, like a knife being sharpened at the dinner table.

My chest tightened.

I pushed the paper deeper into my bag.

Justin leaned over.

"Are we going to study for the next one?"

For a second, I thought he was serious.

Then he grinned.

I laughed.

"Study? Are you sick?"

Caleb laughed too.

But the question stayed with me.

What if I did study?

What if I tried?

The thought scared me more than failing.

Because failing without trying meant I still had an excuse. I could say I did not care. I could say the test was stupid. I could say school was useless.

But trying and failing?

That would mean there was nowhere left to hide.

That would mean maybe my father was right.

Maybe Aaron really was better.

Maybe I really was useless.

So I chose the easier thing.

I chose noise.

I chose jokes.

I chose Justin and Caleb laughing beside me.

I chose to fail loudly.

The bell rang.

Chairs scraped across the floor. Students packed their bags. The classroom filled with movement and voices. I stood with Justin and Caleb, slinging my bag over one shoulder.

Mr. Harris called my name before I reached the door.

"Marshall."

I stopped.

Justin made a face behind the teacher's back.

Caleb whispered, "Again?"

I turned around.

Mr. Harris stood near his desk, holding a stack of books.

"You are better than this," he said.

I smiled automatically.

"People keep saying that."

"Maybe you should ask yourself why."

The room had almost emptied. Only a few students remained, moving slowly near the door.

For a second, I had no joke ready.

That scared me.

So I forced one.

"Maybe everyone just has bad eyesight, sir."

Mr. Harris did not laugh.

"Or maybe they can see you more clearly than you see yourself."

I stared at him.

The words landed somewhere I did not want them to.

Justin called from the hallway.

"Marshall, hurry up!"

I looked away from Mr. Harris.

"Can I go?"

He sighed.

"Yes. Go."

So I went.

Outside, Justin and Caleb were waiting.

"What did he say?" Caleb asked.

I smirked.

"He said I'm a hidden genius."

Justin laughed.

"Very hidden."

We walked down the corridor together, laughing too loudly, pushing each other, making comments about people as they passed. A group of girls walked ahead of us, and Justin said something under his breath. Caleb laughed. I laughed too, even though I saw one of the girls glance back with disgust.

I told myself I did not care.

By then, I had become good at that.

At the gate, Justin pulled out his phone again.

"Check this," he said.

I looked.

Another video.

Another joke that was not really a joke.

Another thing we were too young to understand but old enough to be damaged by.

I laughed because they laughed.

I laughed because laughing was easier than saying, *This feels wrong*.

I laughed because I had built my whole life around never being the one who looked uncomfortable.

The memory began to fade with us standing near the school gate, three boys laughing like we owned the world, even though none of us knew what to do with it.

The corridor blurred first.

Then the classroom.

Then Mr. Harris's tired eyes.

Then Sophie's tightened shoulders.

Then Aaron's name at the dinner table.

Then the red number on my test paper.

34%.

But the lesson stayed.

Another wrong one.

I learned that failure was easier when you made it entertaining.

I learned that disrespect could pass for confidence if people laughed.

I learned that pretending not to care could become a whole personality.

And before the next memory began, I understood something I had spent years denying.

I was not fearless.

I was afraid to try.

Because if I tried and still failed, I would have nothing left to hide behind.

Chapter 7 — Minute Six

By the time I was sixteen, I had learned how to choose a target.

I did not think of it like that then.

Back then, I would have said people made themselves easy to joke about. I would have said they were too sensitive, too quiet, too weird, too serious, too desperate to be liked. I would have said if they did not want attention, they should not act like victims.

That was the lie I told myself.

The truth was uglier.

I noticed weakness because I knew what weakness felt like. I could see it in the way people looked down too quickly, laughed too late, held their books too tightly, or apologized when they had done nothing wrong.

And when I saw it, I attacked it before anyone could see mine.

That was how Thomas became mine.

The memory opened in a classroom I knew too well. Same bright whiteboard. Same rows of desks. Same smell of markers, dust, and teenage sweat. The only difference was that we were older now. Taller. Louder. Better at pretending we knew who we were.

I sat at the back with Justin and Caleb, exactly where everyone expected us to be.

The back row had become more than a place. It was an identity. Teachers saw us there and sighed before we even opened our mouths. Students glanced back at us when something funny happened, waiting for our reaction, like we were the judges of what deserved laughter.

I liked that.

It made me feel important.

At the front of the room, Mrs. Walker was asking for volunteers to present their history projects. Nobody wanted to go first. People looked down at their desks, flipped through papers, pretended to search their bags, or suddenly became very interested in the floor.

Then Thomas raised his hand.

That was the first thing I disliked about him.

Not because raising your hand was wrong.

Because he did it without fear.

He sat two rows from the front, near the window, with his project folder neatly placed on his desk. His uniform was always clean. His shoes

were always polished. His handwriting was small and careful. He did not talk much, but when he did, people listened.

He was not loud.

He did not need to be.

That annoyed me.

Mrs. Walker smiled.

"Thank you, Thomas. Come forward."

Thomas stood up, holding his folder against his chest. He walked to the front of the class and placed his papers on the teacher's desk. His movements were calm, almost too calm, like he had rehearsed everything in his head before doing it.

Justin leaned toward me.

"Of course he's going first."

Caleb whispered, "Bro probably practiced in the mirror."

I smirked.

"Mirror probably begged him to stop."

They laughed quietly.

Thomas began his presentation.

At first, I barely listened. He was talking about causes of conflict, leadership, consequences, and all those serious words teachers loved. His voice was clear, but not loud. He did not joke. He did not rush. He stood there like he believed what he was saying mattered.

That was another thing I hated.

People who believed things mattered made me uncomfortable.

Because if things mattered, then my choices mattered too.

And I could not afford that.

Thomas turned to his next page. A few students actually looked interested. Mrs. Walker nodded as he explained. Even some of the boys who usually laughed with us were quiet.

The room belonged to him.

I felt it happen.

And I did not like it.

So I took it back.

When Thomas said, "This shows how small actions can create larger consequences," I leaned back and whispered loudly enough for the people nearby to hear.

"Wow. Professor Thomas has spoken."

Justin laughed first.

Caleb followed.

A few heads turned.

Thomas paused.

Only for a second.

Then he continued.

That should have annoyed me less.

It annoyed me more.

He did not blush like Daniel had. He did not drop his eyes. He did not stumble over his words. He simply kept going, like my joke had not been strong enough to move him.

So I tried again.

When he turned to pick up another sheet, I whispered, "Careful, everyone. The future president is changing papers."

More laughter.

This time, Thomas looked at me.

Not scared.

Not angry either.

Just calm.

That calmness made something inside me tighten.

Mrs. Walker turned from the board.

"Marshall."

I lifted both hands.

"What? I'm listening."

"No," she said. "You are interrupting."

"I was appreciating the speech."

Justin coughed to hide his laugh.

Mrs. Walker's eyes narrowed.

"Let him finish."

I leaned back, smiling.

"Of course, Miss. We respect greatness."

More laughter.

Thomas looked away and continued.

But now his voice had changed.

Not much. Maybe nobody else noticed. But I did. There was a slight tightness in it, a small crack hidden under the calm.

And because I noticed it, I knew the joke had worked.

That was the beginning.

After that, Thomas became easy to find.

Not physically. He was not always around. He did not push himself into our space. He avoided us when he could.

But in my mind, he was always there.

In class, when he answered a question correctly, I had something to say.

"Thomas saves the day again."

When he handed homework in early, I had something to say.

"Relax, bro, the teacher won't marry you."

When he walked past with books pressed to his chest, I had something to say.

"Careful, the library is escaping."

People laughed.

Not always loudly.

But enough.

And enough was all I needed.

Thomas rarely reacted.

That became the challenge.

With Daniel, embarrassment had come easily. A red face. A broken pencil. A lowered head.

Thomas was different.

He did not give me much. He absorbed things quietly. Too quietly. Like each insult disappeared into him and sank somewhere I could not reach.

That made me want to push harder.

One afternoon, during lunch, I found him sitting under the stairs with a notebook open on his lap. The corridor was mostly empty. People were outside eating, shouting, playing football, pretending the day was better than it was.

Thomas was alone.

That should have been a warning.

Instead, it felt like an invitation.

Justin spotted him first.

"Look who's hiding."

Caleb grinned.

I walked over.

Thomas looked up when our shadows fell across his notebook.

His hand moved quickly to close it.

Too quickly.

That made me curious.

"What are you writing?" I asked.

"Nothing."

Justin laughed. "Nobody writes nothing."

Thomas held the notebook against his chest.

"Just leave me alone."

There it was.

That quiet request.

That soft voice.

That careful way of speaking, like if he used the right words, the world might be kind.

I hated it.

Not because it was weak.

Because some part of me wished I could still speak like that.

I reached for the notebook.

Thomas pulled back.

"Marshall, don't."

The way he said my name made Justin laugh.

"Marshall, don't," Justin repeated in a higher voice.

Caleb joined in. "Please, Marshall, have mercy."

I smiled, but something in Thomas's face made me pause.

He was not scared in the simple way people get scared when they think they might be embarrassed. He looked tired. Like this had already happened too many times before it had even begun.

For one second, I could have stopped.

I knew that.

Even inside the memory, I knew it.

Then Justin said, "Take it."

So I did.

I snatched the notebook from Thomas's hands.

He stood up quickly.

"Give it back."

I held it above my head.

"Relax. I'm just reading."

"It's private."

"Then why bring it to school?"

"That doesn't mean you can take it."

His voice was stronger now.

Students nearby began to notice. A few slowed down. Someone whispered. The audience was forming.

And once there was an audience, I became exactly who they expected me to be.

I opened the notebook.

Thomas stepped forward.

I stepped back.

Justin blocked him with his shoulder.

"Chill," Justin said. "It's not that deep."

It was always "not that deep" when we were the ones holding the knife.

I looked down at the page.

At first, I expected answers, homework, maybe some boring notes. But it was not that. The handwriting was neat but rushed, lines packed close together.

It was not a school notebook.

It was personal.

I should have closed it.

I should have handed it back.

I should have understood that some things were not meant to be touched.

Instead, I read the first line out loud.

"I hate coming to school."

The corridor went quiet.

Thomas's face changed.

Not red.

Not angry.

Empty.

I looked at him.

For the first time, I saw panic.

Real panic.

That should have stopped me.

It did not.

Because the silence around us felt powerful. Everyone was waiting for what I would do next, and I had trained myself to believe that attention was the same as control.

So I kept reading.

"I hate the way they laugh. I hate that teachers see it and still tell me to ignore them."

Someone behind us murmured, "Yo."

Justin's smile faded slightly.

Caleb shifted beside me.

Thomas reached for the notebook again.

"Stop," he said.

One word.

Small.

Broken.

I smiled because I did not know what else to do with the discomfort rising inside me.

"Aww," I said. "Thomas has feelings."

A few students laughed.

Not many.

Just enough to keep me going.

Thomas moved toward me, and Justin pushed him back.

"Don't be dramatic," Justin said.

I flipped the page.

My eyes caught a sentence before my mouth did.

Sometimes I wish I could disappear.

I did not read that one out loud.

I do not know why.

Maybe even I had a line somewhere.

Maybe those words felt too close to something I had once thought in my own room, sitting beside a broken frame, trying to make my head go quiet.

For one second, the notebook grew heavy in my hands.

Thomas looked at me.

He knew I had seen it.

The corridor around us seemed to shrink.

I could have given it back then.

I almost did.

Then Caleb said, "What else does it say?"

And the moment passed.

I closed the notebook and tossed it toward Thomas, but not enough for him to catch it properly. It hit his chest and fell to the floor.

"There," I said. "Your little diary is safe."

Thomas bent down slowly and picked it up.

Nobody laughed now.

Not really.

That made me angry.

I needed laughter to finish the moment. Without it, all that was left was what I had done.

So I forced it.

"Next time, write something less depressing."

Justin laughed once.

Caleb followed.

A few others joined, unsure but willing.

Thomas did not speak.

He held the notebook against his chest and walked away.

His shoulders were straight.

That bothered me.

I wanted him bent.

I wanted him small.

But he walked away straight, and somehow that felt like he had won.

For the next few weeks, Thomas changed.

Not in a way teachers noticed immediately. He still came to class. He still did his work. He still answered questions when asked. But something in him had gone quieter.

Before, his silence had felt calm.

Now it felt locked.

He stopped sitting under the stairs. He stopped writing in that notebook where people could see. He stopped meeting my eyes in the corridor. When we passed him, he moved away before we could speak.

Justin thought it was funny.

"He's scared of you," he said one afternoon.

Caleb grinned. "Marshall ended him."

I smiled.

That was what I was supposed to do.

But inside, the smile did not land properly.

There were moments when I caught Thomas looking at me from across a room, and there was something in his eyes I did not understand then.

Not fear.

Not sadness.

Calculation.

Like he was measuring something.

Like he was storing every word.

One day in Science, we were put into groups.

Of course Thomas ended up near us.

Mrs. Allen, the teacher, said it was random, but teachers always said that when they made terrible decisions on purpose.

Thomas sat across from me at the lab table. Between us were wires, a battery pack, a switch, and a small bulb we were supposed to connect in a circuit.

Justin nudged me under the table.

"This should be fun."

I looked at Thomas.

He was reading the worksheet.

Actually reading it.

I leaned forward.

"Careful, Thomas. Don't electrocute us with your sadness."

Justin laughed.

Caleb covered his mouth.

Thomas did not look up.

Mrs. Allen walked past.

"Focus, boys."

"We are focused," I said. "Thomas is leading us to greatness."

Thomas picked up a wire and connected it to the battery.

His hand was steady.

That annoyed me too.

I wanted a reaction.

Any reaction.

So when he reached for the switch, I moved it slightly out of his reach.

He looked up.

"Can you pass it?"

I placed a hand over my chest.

"So polite."

"Marshall."

There was something different in the way he said my name.

No pleading.

No softness.

Just warning.

Justin noticed it too. His smile grew.

"Oooh."

I pushed the switch toward Thomas, but at the last second, I let it slide off the table. It hit the floor with a small plastic crack.

"Oops."

Thomas stared at it.

Then at me.

The classroom noise faded around us.

For a moment, his face was completely still.

Then he bent down, picked up the switch, and placed it carefully back on the table.

He did not shout.

He did not insult me.

He did not tell the teacher.

He only said, quietly, "One day, you'll go too far."

I laughed.

It came out faster than I expected.

"Is that a threat?"

Thomas looked back at the worksheet.

"No."

Justin leaned forward.

"Sounds like a threat."

Thomas did not answer.

Caleb whispered, "He's actually weird."

I watched Thomas write something down.

His handwriting was still neat.

His face was still calm.

But I saw his hand then.

The pencil was pressed so hard against the paper that the tip snapped.

A tiny sound.

Barely anything.

But I heard it.

For some reason, it stayed with me.

Later that day, I found a note in my locker.

At first, I thought it was from Justin or Caleb. Some stupid joke.
Some drawing. Some insult about a teacher.

But the paper was folded neatly.

Too neatly.

I opened it.

There were only six words.

You do not know what helpless feels like.

I stared at the sentence for a long time.

My first feeling was anger.

How dare he?

Thomas, of all people. Quiet Thomas. Notebook Thomas. Teacher's-pet Thomas. The boy who looked at the floor when I passed.

I crumpled the note and shoved it into my pocket.

When Justin asked what it was, I laughed.

"Nothing."

"What did it say?"

"Nothing important."

But the words stayed with me longer than I wanted them to.

You do not know what helpless feels like.

He was wrong, of course.

I knew helpless.

I knew it better than he thought.

I knew it in the shape of my father's hand. I knew it in the sound of my mother crying downstairs. I knew it in Jenna's quiet fear. I knew it in the red numbers on my test papers and the silence after a teacher said I was wasting my potential.

But Thomas did not know that.

All he knew was the version of me that laughed.

The version that took things.

The version that turned people into jokes.

And maybe that was the worst part.

I had hidden so well that even the people I hurt could not see the hurt inside me.

Not that it mattered.

Pain did not excuse pain.

I know that now.

I did not know it then.

Or maybe I knew and ignored it because ignoring things was easier.

The memory began to fade near the lockers.

The corridor stretched long and blurry. Justin's voice disappeared first. Then Caleb's laugh. Then the rows of lockers. Then Thomas at the end of the hallway, standing still, watching me with an expression I could not understand.

But the feeling stayed.

Not guilt.

Not yet.

Something colder.

A warning.

I thought Thomas was weak because he stayed quiet.

I did not understand that silence could be filling up.

I did not understand that people do not break all at once.

Sometimes they crack slowly, while everyone else is laughing.

Chapter 8 — The Last Laugh

I should have stopped after the note.

That was what I understood later.

Not then.

Back then, the note did not feel like a warning. It felt like a challenge. It felt like Thomas had stepped out of the place I had put him in and dared me to push him back down.

You do not know what helpless feels like.

I hated that sentence.

I hated the way it stayed in my head during lessons. I hated the way I could still see his handwriting even after I had crushed the paper and thrown it into the bin. I hated that a boy like Thomas had managed to make me think about him when he was not even in the room.

So I decided to remind him who people listened to.

The memory opened on a Friday afternoon, the kind of Friday that made everyone restless before the final bell even rang. The classroom was too warm. The air felt thick. People were half-listening, half-packing, pretending they cared about the lesson while already thinking about going home.

Mrs. Walker was at the front, trying to explain the instructions for our next assignment.

Nobody was really listening.

Justin was drawing on the corner of his notebook. Caleb was leaning back in his chair, balancing on two legs even though teachers had told him a hundred times not to. I sat between them, spinning a pen through my fingers and watching Thomas.

He was sitting near the window.

Alone.

His notebook was closed now. It stayed closed most of the time after what I had done under the stairs. He kept it inside his bag, zipped away like something dangerous.

That should have made me feel guilty.

Instead, it made me curious.

People always think cruelty is loud. Sometimes it is quieter than that. Sometimes it is just watching someone protect something and deciding you want to touch it again.

Mrs. Walker turned to write on the board.

That was when Thomas's phone buzzed.

It was small. Almost nothing. A short vibration from inside his blazer pocket.

But I heard it.

Maybe because I was already watching him.

Thomas glanced down quickly, then slipped the phone halfway out under the desk. His face changed when he read the message. Not much, but enough.

His mouth tightened.

His eyes moved to the door.

Then he put the phone away.

Justin leaned toward me.

"What's wrong with him?"

I shrugged.

"Probably got a love letter from his calculator."

Caleb laughed.

Thomas did not turn around.

That annoyed me.

I wanted him to hear.

I wanted him to react.

Then Mrs. Walker asked everyone to take out their assignment drafts.

Thomas reached into his bag.

His phone slipped out with his notebook.

Only for a second.

But long enough for me to see the screen light up again.

A name flashed across it.

Mum

And underneath it, part of a message.

I'm sorry. I know today is hard...

I did not know what it meant.

I did not care enough to understand it.

But I cared enough to use it.

When the bell rang, the classroom exploded into noise. Chairs scraped. Bags zipped. Students rushed toward the door like the building was on fire.

Thomas packed slowly.

Too slowly.

Justin and Caleb were already standing near my desk.

"Come on," Justin said.

I did not move.

I watched Thomas put his notebook into his bag.

Then his phone buzzed again.

He picked it up.

His face changed again.

This time, I saw pain.

Real pain.

Not embarrassment. Not irritation. Something deeper.

Something private.

That should have been enough.

It was not.

I walked over.

Justin and Caleb followed, because by then they always did.

Thomas noticed our shadows before he saw our faces.

His hand tightened around his phone.

"What?" he asked.

His voice was tired.

That made me smile.

"Relax," I said. "I just want to know why you've been acting like someone died."

The words came out before I understood them.

Thomas went still.

Completely still.

The kind of stillness that makes the air around a person feel dangerous.

Justin looked at me.

Caleb stopped smiling.

For once, even they felt it.

But I had already said it, and the worst thing a boy like me could do was back down in front of an audience.

So I kept going.

"What?" I said. "Did I guess right?"

Thomas's face changed.

His eyes went flat.

"Move," he said.

He tried to step past me.

I blocked him.

"Say please."

"Move."

Justin laughed nervously.

"Bro, just let him go."

That should have warned me too.

Justin never told me to stop unless something felt wrong.

But Thomas had written that note.

Thomas had looked at me like he knew something about helplessness.

Thomas had made me feel small without even raising his voice.

And I hated him for it.

So I reached for his phone.

Thomas pulled it back.

"Don't."

I smiled.

"Why? What's on there?"

"Marshall."

There it was again.

My name in his mouth.

Not begging this time.

Warning.

I should have listened.

Instead, I snatched the phone from his hand.

It happened fast. One second it was his. The next, it was mine.

Thomas lunged for it.

Justin grabbed his arm without thinking.

"Chill," Justin said. "He's just joking."

Thomas's voice cracked.

"Give it back."

Something in that crack made people turn around.

The corridor was filling with students now. Some heading home. Some waiting for friends. Some stopping because they could sense a scene beginning.

I held the phone above my head.

"Relax, Thomas. I'm just checking if your mum also writes essays."

A few people laughed.

Not many.

But enough.

Thomas's face had gone pale.

"Give it back," he said again.

His voice was lower now.

I looked at the screen.

The message was still open.

I read it before I meant to.

I'm sorry. I know today is hard. Your dad would be proud of you.

For a second, everything inside me stopped.

His dad.

I understood then.

Not fully, but enough.

Someone had died.

Maybe recently. Maybe not. But today meant something. His mother's message meant something. His silence meant something.

And I had my hand around it.

I could have given the phone back.

I should have.

Even Justin looked uncomfortable now.

"Marshall," he muttered. "Just give it."

But the corridor was watching.

And I had spent too many years believing that the worst thing I could do was look weak in front of people.

So I laughed.

It sounded wrong.

Even to me.

"Aww," I said, reading the message louder. "Your dad would be proud of you."

The corridor went quiet.

Not normal quiet.

Horrified quiet.

Thomas stopped moving.

For one second, he looked like he had left his own body.

Then I added, because I was stupid and cruel and desperate to turn the silence back into laughter:

"Proud of what? Your little notebook?"

No one laughed.

Not even Caleb.

Not even Justin.

The silence around me became too large.

I suddenly wanted to undo it. I wanted someone to laugh so it would become a joke again. I wanted Thomas to shout, to push me, to do anything that would make me feel less like the villain in the room.

But Thomas did not shout.

He just looked at me.

And I saw something break.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

Something behind his eyes simply closed.

He held out his hand.

"Give me my phone."

His voice was calm.

Too calm.

I tossed it to him.

He caught it.

For a moment, nobody moved.

Then Thomas stepped closer.

Justin let go of his arm.

Thomas looked at me like he was seeing me clearly for the first time.

"You think everything is funny," he said.

I smirked, but it did not feel natural.

"Most things are."

He nodded slowly.

"Okay."

That was all.

Okay.

One word.

No threat.

No tears.

No shouting.

He turned and walked away.

People moved out of his path.

Nobody laughed.

I stood there with the whole corridor looking at me, and for the first time in years, attention did not feel good.

It felt like a spotlight on something rotten.

Caleb scratched the back of his neck.

"That was... kind of deep, bro."

I turned on him fast.

"What?"

He looked away.

"Nothing."

Justin did not speak.

That made me angrier than Caleb's words.

"What?" I said to him. "You too?"

Justin shrugged.

"I just think maybe you went too far."

There it was.

The phrase Thomas had said in Science.

One day, you'll go too far.

I shoved past them.

"Whatever."

I walked down the corridor before either of them could follow me.

My face was hot. My hands were shaking. But I told myself it was anger. I told myself everyone was being dramatic. I told myself Thomas had wanted attention and now he had it.

I told myself anything except the truth.

The truth was that I had known exactly where to press.

And I pressed anyway.

For the next few days, Thomas did not come to school.

At first, I acted like I did not notice.

When Mrs. Walker called his name during registration and there was no answer, I looked out of the window. When his seat stayed empty, I made jokes about how peaceful the class was. When Justin did not laugh as loudly as usual, I told him he was becoming boring.

But I noticed.

Of course I noticed.

Empty seats have a way of becoming louder than people.

By Wednesday, rumours had started moving through the school.

Someone said Thomas was sick.

Someone said his mother had complained.

Someone said a teacher had spoken to the headmaster.

Someone said Thomas had cried in the office before going home.

I laughed at that one.

Too loudly.

Justin stared at me.

"You good?"

I rolled my eyes.

"Why do you keep asking me that?"

"Because you're acting weird."

"I'm acting normal."

"No," he said. "You're acting like you're trying too hard."

For a second, I wanted to hit him.

Not because he was wrong.

Because he was right.

On Thursday, Thomas came back.

He walked into class just before the bell, quiet as always. But something was different. His face looked tired, like he had not slept properly. His eyes moved across the room and stopped on me for one second.

There was no fear in them.

No sadness either.

Just a kind of calm that made my stomach tighten.

He sat down.

Mrs. Walker watched him carefully.

I saw her do it.

That annoyed me too.

Everyone was careful with him now. Teachers spoke softer. Students moved around him like he was made of glass. Even Justin and Caleb stayed quiet when he passed.

I hated it.

Not because I wanted Thomas hurt.

At least, that is what I told myself.

I hated it because his pain had become visible, and mine never had.

Nobody had stepped softly around me when my father hit me. Nobody had watched me carefully when I came to school with anger sitting behind my eyes. Nobody had lowered their voice when I was breaking.

So I resented him for being broken in a way people could see.

That was ugly.

I know that now.

At lunch, Thomas sat alone again, but not under the stairs. He sat outside near the far side of the courtyard, where the old storage building stood behind the classrooms. It was an ugly part of the school, full of locked rooms, broken chairs, old sports equipment, and things nobody used until they needed them.

I saw him there.

He was not eating.

He was holding his phone.

Typing.

Deleting.

Typing again.

Justin followed my eyes.

"Leave it," he said.

I looked at him.

"What?"

"Just leave him."

Caleb nodded slowly.

"Yeah. It's getting weird."

I laughed.

"You people are scared of Thomas now?"

Justin did not laugh.

That bothered me more than it should have.

I stood up.

"Watch this."

Justin grabbed my wrist.

"Marshall, don't."

For one second, his hand around my wrist reminded me of my father grabbing my shirt on the stairs.

I pulled away hard.

"Don't touch me."

Justin let go.

I walked toward Thomas.

Every step felt like I was proving something, though I did not know what.

Thomas looked up when I reached him.

He did not seem surprised.

That made it worse.

"Back from your holiday?" I asked.

He stared at me.

No answer.

I smiled.

"You missed us?"

Still nothing.

I leaned closer.

"You know, if you wanted attention, you could have just asked."

Thomas put his phone into his pocket slowly.

Then he stood up.

He was not taller than me, but in that moment, he did not feel small.

"Are you done?" he asked.

The question hit me harder than an insult would have.

Because he sounded bored.

Like I was nothing.

Like my words had finally stopped working.

I stepped closer.

"I'm done when I say I'm done."

Thomas looked at me for a long moment.

Then he said quietly, "You will be."

I laughed, but it came out too sharp.

"Another threat?"

"No."

He picked up his bag.

Then he walked away again.

But before he did, his eyes moved past me.

Toward the storage building.

Only for a second.

I saw it.

I did not understand it.

Not then.

The memory shifted.

Days passed quickly after that, in broken pieces.

Thomas in class, silent.

Thomas in the corridor, watching.

Thomas near the office, speaking to Mrs. Walker.

Thomas outside the storage building, standing still with his phone in his hand.

Thomas looking at me like he had stopped waiting for me to become better.

Meanwhile, I got louder.

Louder in class.

Louder with Justin and Caleb.

Louder when Sophie walked past.

Louder when teachers warned me.

Louder because Thomas's silence had started to feel like a room closing in.

By Friday, the school felt different.

Maybe it was only the memory making it that way.

Maybe my dying brain was adding shadows where there had not been any.

But I remembered the air being heavy that day.

I remembered the corridors smelling like rain and dust.

I remembered Thomas walking past me after lunch and saying nothing, not even when Caleb muttered something under his breath.

I remembered thinking I had won because he did not answer.

Now I know silence was not surrender.

It was preparation.

At the end of the day, Mrs. Walker gave us a final warning about unfinished assignments. People packed their bags. The bell rang. The week ended in the usual burst of noise.

I stood near the doorway with Justin and Caleb.

Thomas walked past us.

His shoulder brushed mine.

Not hard.

Barely anything.

But enough.

I grabbed his bag strap.

"Watch where you're going."

He stopped.

The corridor thinned around us.

Justin groaned quietly.

"Marshall..."

Thomas turned.

For a moment, we just looked at each other.

Then he said, "Let go."

I smiled.

"Say please."

Something flickered in his face.

Not fear.

Not anger.

Decision.

I did not understand that look until later.

Until the door.

Until the smoke.

Until the fire.

Thomas reached into his pocket and pulled out a folded paper.

He pressed it into my hand.

"What's this?" I asked.

"Something you forgot."

Then he pulled his bag free and walked away.

I unfolded the paper.

It was the note.

The same sentence.

You do not know what helpless feels like.

But this time, there was another line underneath it.

You will.

I stared at it.

Justin leaned over.

"What does it say?"

I crumpled it before he could read.

"Nothing."

My voice sounded normal.

At least, I hoped it did.

But something cold had moved through me.

Not fear.

Not exactly.

Fear would have meant I understood the danger.

I did not.

I only felt insulted.

Challenged.

Like Thomas had thrown something at me and expected me not to throw it back harder.

I looked down the corridor.

He was gone.

The memory began to fade with the note still crushed in my fist.

The hallway blurred first. Then Justin's voice. Then Caleb's laugh. Then the far corner where Thomas had disappeared. The paper in my hand turned pale, then grey, then nothing.

But the warning stayed.

Not because I listened to it.

Because I did not.

That was the last mistake before everything changed.

I thought Thomas was weak because he stayed quiet.

I thought his silence meant I had won.

I thought the last laugh belonged to me.

I did not understand that some people stop speaking when they start planning.

Chapter 9 — The Door Stayed Closed

Thomas did not disappear after that.

That would have been easier to understand.

If he had stopped coming to school, if he had cried in the office, if he had shouted at me in front of everyone, then maybe I could have placed him into a shape I understood. Victim. Coward. Attention seeker. Weak boy.

But Thomas kept coming.

That was worse.

He came to class. He answered questions. He wrote notes. He walked through the corridors with his bag held over one shoulder. He did everything he was supposed to do.

Only now, something about him had changed.

He was quiet before.

Now he was silent.

There is a difference.

Quiet people still seem like they are part of the world. They listen. They react. They look away. They smile sometimes, even if the smile is small.

Silent people are somewhere else.

Thomas was somewhere else.

The memory opened on a Monday afternoon, three days after he had pressed the note into my hand.

You will.

Those two words followed me longer than I wanted to admit.

I told myself they meant nothing. I told myself Thomas was trying to scare me because he had finally learned how to be dramatic. I told myself if he really wanted to do something, he would have done it already.

Still, whenever I saw him, my body noticed before my mind did.

In the corridor.

By the lockers.

Near the science block.

Outside the old storage building.

Always there.

Always looking like he was waiting for something.

Justin noticed too.

"You and Thomas still doing that weird silent-war thing?" he asked at lunch.

I took a drink from my bottle and shrugged.

"There's no war. He's just obsessed with me."

Caleb laughed.

Justin did not.

That annoyed me.

"What?" I asked.

"Nothing."

"You've been saying 'nothing' a lot."

Justin leaned back against the bench and looked across the courtyard. Thomas was standing near the office, talking to Mrs. Walker. His face was calm. Hers was serious.

"I just think you should leave it," Justin said.

I laughed.

"Since when did you become his lawyer?"

"I'm serious."

"That's your problem."

Caleb glanced between us.

"Bro, even I think Thomas is acting strange."

I looked at him.

"You too?"

Caleb lifted both hands. "I'm just saying."

They were scared.

That was what I told myself.

Justin was scared. Caleb was scared. Thomas was trying to make everyone scared.

And I hated fear.

Especially when it was mine.

So I turned it into anger.

That afternoon, I was louder than usual. In History, I interrupted Mrs. Walker twice. In Science, I made a joke about Thomas carrying half the library in his bag. In the corridor, when Sophie walked past, I said something under my breath just loud enough for Justin to hear.

He did not laugh.

That made me feel even worse.

By the end of the day, I was tired in a way I did not understand. My throat hurt from talking. My face hurt from smiling. My chest felt tight, like I had been running from something without moving.

The final bell rang.

Students poured out of classrooms, loud and restless, filling the corridor with the usual end-of-day noise. Lockers slammed. Shoes squeaked. Someone shouted for a friend. A teacher told a group of boys to stop running.

I walked with Justin and Caleb toward the main gate.

Then my phone buzzed.

I pulled it from my pocket.

Unknown number.

The message was short.

Your bag is in the old storage room.

I stopped walking.

Justin bumped into my shoulder.

"What?"

I stared at the message.

"What is it?" Caleb asked.

I looked down at my side.

My bag was not there.

For one second, confusion moved through me. Then anger followed.

I had left it by the classroom door for barely two minutes when I went to the bathroom after last period. I thought Justin had picked it up. Or Caleb. Or maybe I had forgotten it inside.

But now I knew.

Thomas.

Of course.

Justin leaned closer.

"What does it say?"

I turned the phone away.

"Nothing."

He narrowed his eyes.

"That doesn't look like nothing."

"It's my bag."

"Where?"

I looked toward the old side of the school.

The storage building stood behind the classrooms, partly hidden by the science block. It was not really abandoned, but it felt abandoned. Old uniforms, sports equipment, broken desks, boxes of paper, decorations from events nobody remembered — all of it ended up there.

Teachers used it when they needed something.

Students avoided it unless they were hiding.

The message came again.

Come alone. Unless you're scared.

My jaw tightened.

There it was.

That word.

Scared.

A simple word. Six letters. Small enough to fit inside a message, sharp enough to move my whole body.

Justin must have seen my face change.

"Marshall," he said slowly, "what's going on?"

I pushed my phone into my pocket.

"Thomas took my bag."

Caleb laughed once. "No way."

Justin did not laugh.

"Don't go."

I looked at him.

"What?"

"Don't go," he repeated. "This is obviously weird."

I smiled.

"You think I'm scared of Thomas?"

"I think he's not joking."

"Good. Neither am I."

Justin stepped in front of me.

"Marshall, just tell a teacher."

That made me laugh for real.

"Tell a teacher? What are we, seven?"

"This isn't funny."

"That's because you stopped being funny."

I walked around him.

He grabbed my arm.

"Bro, I'm serious."

I pulled away.

"Don't touch me."

The words came out sharper than I meant them to.

Justin let go.

For a second, something passed between us. Not anger exactly.
Something tired. Something disappointed.

Caleb shifted awkwardly.

"Maybe we can all go," he said.

The phone buzzed again.

Alone.

I looked at the screen.

Then at Justin.

Then at Caleb.

My pride made the decision before my brain could.

"I'll be back in five minutes."

Justin shook his head.

"Marshall—"

"I said I'll be back."

I walked away before he could answer.

The noise of the school faded as I moved toward the old building. The main corridor emptied behind me. The classrooms grew quieter. The bright, crowded parts of the school disappeared, replaced by the side paths teachers forgot about unless something needed fixing.

The sky had darkened slightly. Rain clouds pressed low above the school roofs. The air smelled damp, like dust waiting to become mud.

I told myself I was angry.

I told myself I was not afraid.

I told myself a lot of things.

The old storage building stood with its narrow windows and peeling paint. One of the outside lights flickered even though it was not dark yet. The door at the front was half-open.

That should have stopped me.

It did not.

I pushed it open.

Inside, the hallway was dim and smelled of old paper, cleaning chemicals, and something stale I could not name. The floor was concrete. My footsteps sounded too loud.

"Thomas," I called.

No answer.

I walked further in.

There were three doors along the hallway. The first was locked. The second was slightly open, showing stacked chairs and a broken notice board. The third had a small label taped to it.

STORAGE ROOM B

My bag sat just inside the doorway.

Black.

Unzipped.

Waiting.

I stopped.

For one second, I did wonder why it was so easy.

Then Thomas spoke behind me.

"Pick it up."

I turned.

He stood at the end of the hallway, near the entrance. He looked calm. Too calm. His hands were in his pockets. His uniform was neat. His face gave nothing away.

I smiled because I did not know what else to do.

"So this is your big revenge?"

He did not answer.

I stepped into the storage room and grabbed my bag.

"You stole my bag just to make me walk here?" I said. "That's actually sad."

Thomas watched me.

I slung the bag over my shoulder.

"You know, for someone who writes depressing diary entries, your planning is boring."

Still nothing.

That irritated me.

I stepped toward him.

"What? No speech?"

Thomas looked past me.

At the room.

Then back at my face.

"I wanted to see if you would come."

I laughed.

"Of course I came. You took my bag."

"No," he said. "You came because I said you were scared."

The laugh died halfway in my throat.

For the first time, I looked at him properly.

His calmness was not empty.

It was chosen.

That made it worse.

"Move," I said.

Thomas tilted his head slightly.

"You say that a lot to people."

"What?"

"Move. Shut up. Say please. Look down." His voice stayed quiet. "You like telling people what to do."

I stepped closer.

"Are you trying to be deep again?"

"No."

"Then move."

He did not.

I walked toward the door.

Thomas stepped back.

Not away.

Into the hallway.

His hand came out of his pocket.

There was a key in it.

For one second, I did not understand.

Then he pulled the storage room door.

I moved fast.

Not fast enough.

The door slammed between us.

The sound filled the hallway.

Metal against frame.

Final.

I grabbed the handle immediately.

It did not turn.

For a second, all I felt was disbelief.

Then anger.

Hot.

Embarrassing.

Instant.

"Open the door."

Thomas did not answer.

I twisted the handle harder.

"Thomas."

Still nothing.

I kicked the door once.

"Open the door!"

From the other side, his voice came quietly.

"You do not know what helpless feels like."

My stomach tightened.

I laughed.

It sounded wrong in the small room.

"You're actually insane."

No answer.

I hit the door with my fist.

"You think this makes you strong?"

Silence.

I moved back and looked around the room.

It was dark except for a thin strip of light coming from the high window. Shelves lined the walls. Old boxes were stacked near the corner. A pile of clothes sat in a plastic basket. There were broken folders, dusty files, a cracked mirror from some old drama production, and a metal cabinet with one missing handle.

It smelled like dust and old fabric.

I turned back to the door.

"Thomas, open it."

My voice was still angry, but something underneath it had shifted.

I hated that.

I hated that I could hear the difference.

On the other side, Thomas finally spoke.

"I planned this."

The words were soft.

Too soft.

I froze.

"What?"

"I planned it," he said again. "The key. Your bag. The message. All of it."

For one second, I pictured him doing it.

Watching me.

Waiting.

Thinking.

Quietly building this moment while I laughed around him.

My hands tightened.

"You're proud of that?"

"No."

"Then open the door."

"I wanted you to know."

"Know what?"

"What it feels like when people hear you and still do nothing."

I punched the door.

Pain shot through my knuckles.

"You're a coward!"

Maybe that was the wrong word.

Maybe all of them had been the wrong words.

Thomas went silent.

Then he said, "Ten minutes."

"What?"

"I'll come back in ten minutes."

My breathing quickened.

"You're joking."

"No."

"Thomas, open the door."

"Ten minutes," he repeated.

His footsteps started moving away.

Panic touched my throat then.

Small at first.

Then larger.

"Thomas!"

The footsteps stopped.

I pressed my face closer to the door.

"Thomas, you idiot, this isn't funny."

His voice came from farther away now.

"It was never funny."

Then the footsteps continued.

I stood there, staring at the door.

For a moment, I could not move.

Then I laughed.

I laughed because that was what I did when I was trapped inside a feeling I did not understand. I laughed because anger was safer than fear. I laughed because somewhere deep inside me, a seven-year-old boy was still trying not to cry.

"Fine!" I shouted. "Walk away!"

My voice bounced off the shelves and came back smaller.

I kicked the door again.

Harder.

It did nothing.

I pulled out my phone.

No signal.

Of course.

I held it higher, moving around the storage room like an idiot, watching the bars appear and disappear, never long enough to matter.

"Come on," I muttered.

Nothing.

I tried calling Justin.

The call failed.

I tried again.

Failed.

My chest tightened.

I turned back to the door.

"Thomas!"

No answer.

The room seemed darker now.

I told myself ten minutes was nothing.

I told myself he would come back.

I told myself Justin and Caleb would notice I was gone.

I told myself a teacher would pass by.

I told myself I was not scared.

Then something cracked near the shelf.

Small.

Sharp.

I turned around.

At first, I saw nothing.

Then the old socket near the corner spat a tiny blue spark.

I stared at it.

Another spark.

Then another.

A thin thread of smoke curled upward from the wall.

For one second, my brain refused to understand what it meant.

Then the pile of clothes beneath the shelf began to smoke.

"No," I whispered.

The spark snapped again.

This time, the fabric caught.

A small orange flame appeared.

Tiny.

Almost harmless.

Then it grew.

The memory started shaking then, as if even my mind did not want to stay inside it.

I backed toward the door.

"No, no, no."

The flame climbed the clothes slowly at first, then faster, eating through fabric, reaching toward loose papers stacked beside the shelf.

I slammed both fists against the door.

"THOMAS!"

No answer.

The smoke thickened.

My throat burned.

I pulled my shirt over my nose.

"Open the door!" I shouted. "Thomas!"

Somewhere far away, or maybe only in the memory, I heard my own voice from the beginning.

Thomas, you coward! You think locking me in here makes you strong?

Now I knew what helpless felt like.

And I hated him for being right.

The room blurred.

Not because the memory was fading.

Because the smoke was rising.

Because the fire was growing.

Because this was no longer just memory.

This was the moment that brought me back to the beginning.

The door stayed closed.

And everything after that was smoke.

Chapter 10 — Minute Seven

At first, there was only smoke.

Not memory.

Not thought.

Not even fear.

Just smoke.

It filled my mouth, my nose, my throat, my chest. It pressed into me like something alive, like it had hands, like it wanted to climb inside and take every part of me that still belonged to the world.

I could not tell if I was back in the storage room or still inside the memory. The two had folded into each other. Thomas's footsteps. The locked door. The orange light. The note in my hand.

You will.

I had.

I knew what helpless felt like now.

I knew it in the useless twist of the door handle. I knew it in my broken voice shouting for someone who was not coming. I knew it in the way

my body kept begging for air even after my mind understood there was not enough left.

I had spent years making people feel small.

Now the room had made me small.

The fire snapped somewhere behind me. The sound was sharp and hungry. I tried to move, but my body did not obey properly. My legs felt far away. My arms felt heavy. My head pulsed where it had hit the concrete.

I wanted to be angry.

Anger was familiar. Anger was easy. Anger gave me something to hold.

But even anger was slipping.

I thought death would be loud.

It was not.

It was quiet in the worst way.

Quiet like a classroom after a joke goes too far.

Quiet like my mother staring out of the car window.

Quiet like Jenna standing in a doorway, holding her breath.

Quiet like Thomas looking at me after I read his mother's message.

Then the smoke opened.

Not like a door.

Like a wound.

And the memories came all at once.

I saw Jenna first.

Not the little girl from the backyard, laughing on the concrete with her missing sock and bright eyes. Older Jenna. The one who had learned to move carefully around the house. The one who knew when to speak and when to disappear. The one who watched me become someone she no longer knew.

She was standing in the hallway, small hands wrapped around the straps of her schoolbag, watching me shout at our mother because my uniform was not washed.

It had not even been her fault.

Mum had worked late that day. The washing machine had stopped halfway through. My shirt was still damp, and I had exploded like the world had betrayed me.

"You never do anything right!" I had shouted.

The words had come out fast.

Too fast.

Mum had frozen.

Jenna had flinched.

I saw it now.

I saw the way Jenna looked at me after I said it. Not surprised. That was the worst part. She was not surprised anymore.

She was used to me.

I had become another version of my father, and I had not even noticed.

The memory shifted.

I saw my mother at the dining table late at night.

The house was dark except for the small kitchen light. She sat alone with bills spread in front of her, one hand pressed against her forehead. Her phone lay beside her. My father was not home.

I had come downstairs for water.

She looked up quickly and smiled, pretending she had not been crying.

"Can't sleep?" she asked.

I shrugged.

"No."

She opened her mouth like she wanted to say something else. Maybe she wanted to ask if I was okay. Maybe she wanted to apologize for all the times she had been too tired or too afraid to protect me. Maybe she wanted me to sit with her.

I did not give her the chance.

I took the water and went back upstairs.

I remembered thinking she looked weak.

Now I saw the truth.

She looked lonely.

And I had left her there.

The memory pulled harder.

Daniel appeared.

Nine years old. Red ears. Broken pencil. Lunchbox gripped in both hands. But this time, I did not see him from above, the way I had back then.

I saw him from inside himself.

I felt the heat in his face when everyone laughed. I felt his hands shake under the desk. I felt the way he kept his eyes down because looking up would make the tears fall faster.

I heard my own voice again.

It is important to stop acting like a teacher's pet.

The class laughed.

I had thought laughter made me powerful.

But from where Daniel stood, laughter sounded like a door closing.

The memory changed.

Sophie.

She sat two rows ahead of me in English, shoulders tight, pen frozen above her book. Justin's voice whispered something stupid. Caleb laughed. I laughed too. Then I said something worse.

I saw what I had not cared to see then.

Sophie did not cry.

She did not shout.

She simply became smaller in her own body.

She pulled her cardigan closer. She held her books tighter when she walked past. She checked who was behind her before entering classrooms after that.

I had not touched her.

But I had still made her feel unsafe.

The thought hit harder than I expected.

Because all my life, I had measured harm by what left marks.

A slap.

A bruise.

A broken frame.

A cut.

But some damage did not show on skin.

Some damage changed how a person walked into a room.

Then came Thomas.

Not one memory.

All of them.

Thomas presenting at the front of class, voice steady until I cracked it.

Thomas under the stairs, notebook held to his chest.

Thomas reaching for his phone.

Thomas standing in the corridor while I read his mother's message aloud.

Thomas saying, *You think everything is funny.*

Thomas pressing the note into my hand.

Thomas looking at me through the storage room door, calm because he had finally found a way to give me what I had given him.

I wanted to hate him.

A part of me still did.

He had locked the door.

He had planned it.

He had left me there.

But the memories would not let me hold only that truth.

They showed me the other ones too.

The way he had asked me to stop.

The way I had not.

The way teachers told him to ignore it.

The way students laughed because it was easier than defending him.

The way I kept pushing, not because he deserved it, but because he survived it.

I had thought Thomas was weak because he stayed quiet.

But silence had been the only place he had left to live.

And I had invaded that too.

The smoke moved through the memories.

It curled around classrooms, corridors, the backyard, the church, the dining table, the storage room. It wrapped itself around every version of me.

Seven-year-old me laughing with Jenna.

Nine-year-old me mocking Daniel.

Twelve-year-old me standing outside church, saying I did not believe.

Thirteen-year-old me beside the broken frame, thinking pain was peace.

Fourteen-year-old me holding up a failed test like a trophy.

Sixteen-year-old me reading Thomas's grief aloud because I was too proud to stop.

They all looked at me.

Every version.

Every mistake.

Every joke that had not been a joke.

For the first time, I did not look away.

I had spent my life saying nothing mattered.

It had sounded clever when I was angry.

It had sounded strong when people expected me to care.

It had sounded like freedom when religion felt empty and school felt impossible and home felt unsafe.

But it had never been freedom.

It had been fear wearing a mask.

If nothing mattered, then I did not have to feel guilty.

If nothing mattered, then I did not have to try.

If nothing mattered, then hurting people was just noise.

But everything had mattered.

That was the terrible thing.

The toy car mattered.

Jenna's laughter mattered.

Daniel's broken pencil mattered.

Sophie's tightened shoulders mattered.

My mother crying quietly downstairs mattered.

Thomas's notebook mattered.

The words I said mattered.

The words I did not say mattered too.

I wanted more time.

The thought came so suddenly it hurt.

Not a lifetime.

Not even a year.

Just one hour.

One hour to find Jenna and tell her I remembered the backyard. One hour to tell my mother she had not failed me alone. One hour to tell Daniel I knew he had not deserved it. One hour to tell Sophie that laughing had been cowardice, not confidence. One hour to tell Thomas—

I stopped.

What would I tell Thomas?

That I was sorry?

The word felt too small now.

Sorry was what people said when they stepped on your shoe.

Sorry was not enough for years of turning someone into a joke.

But it was all I had left.

And I did not even have breath to say it.

The fire cracked louder.

The storage room returned around me in pieces.

The ceiling.

The shelves.

The orange light.

The smoke.

My hand lay on the concrete, fingers curled slightly like I was still trying to hold onto something. My chest rose once, barely. My throat burned. My eyes watered until the room became a blur of shadow and flame.

Somewhere outside, I thought I heard shouting.

Maybe real.

Maybe memory.

A voice called my name.

Not Thomas.

Not Justin.

Not Caleb.

A woman's voice.

Maybe my mother.

Maybe nobody.

I tried to answer.

Nothing came out.

The door shook.

Or maybe my vision did.

The world had become too thin to trust.

I thought of God then.

Not the way my father had wanted me to.

Not as a threat.

Not as a judge.

Not as someone waiting to punish me.

Just as a question.

If He was real, He was silent.

If He was not, the silence was the same.

For once, I did not try to turn the question into a joke.

For once, I let myself be afraid.

The last memory came softly.

The backyard again.

Jenna laughing.

The yellow toy car wobbling across the concrete.

My mother smiling in the doorway.

Me, small and bright and unbroken, believing that making someone laugh meant giving them joy.

I wanted to stay there.

I wanted to be that boy.

But the memory would not let me lie.

I had been that boy.

And I had also become this one.

Both were true.

That was the hardest part.

A person could begin as someone gentle and still become cruel.

Pain could explain you.

It did not excuse you.

The door shook again.

This time, I was sure.

Someone was outside.

"Marshall!"

The voice was far away, muffled by metal and smoke.

Thomas?

I could not tell.

The handle rattled.

A crash.

More shouting.

Too late, I thought.

The words did not come with anger.

Only understanding.

Too late for the door.

Too late for the apology.

Too late for the boy I had been.

My vision darkened at the edges.

The fire became softer.

The smoke became lighter.

The room became less real.

And in the final second, I understood something I should have understood while I was alive.

I thought nothing mattered because nothing lasted forever.

But I was wrong.

Things do not need to last forever to matter.

Sometimes seven minutes is enough to see a whole life.

Sometimes one cruel word is enough to change a person.

Sometimes one locked door is enough to end two futures.

The last thing I saw was not the fire.

It was Jenna's face.

Not crying.

Not afraid.

Laughing.

The way she had before I taught her to fear me.

I tried to hold onto that sound.

I tried to follow it somewhere.

But the laughter faded.

The light folded in.

And then there was nothing.

Epilogue — After the Door

Thomas had planned everything except the fire.

That was what he told himself at first.

He planned the key. He planned the message. He planned the empty corridor after school. He planned the old storage room nobody used unless they were looking for broken chairs, old uniforms, boxes of paper, or decorations from events people had already forgotten.

He planned Marshall's bag sitting just inside the doorway.

He planned the words.

Come alone. Unless you're scared.

He planned to lock the door.

He planned to walk away.

He planned to come back after ten minutes.

Ten minutes.

That was all.

Ten minutes for Marshall to feel what Thomas had felt for years. Ten minutes of helplessness. Ten minutes of shouting and being ignored. Ten minutes of knowing someone could hear you and still choose to do nothing.

Thomas had wanted Marshall scared.

He had wanted him small.

He had wanted him to understand.

He had not wanted him dead.

That was the part Thomas kept repeating when the police came.

"I didn't know," he said.

His voice sounded far away, even to himself.

The officer stood in front of him, holding a notebook. Another officer was speaking to the headteacher near the office door. Teachers moved through the corridor with pale faces. Students whispered in corners, even though they had been told to go home.

Outside, red and blue lights flashed against the school walls.

Thomas could still smell smoke.

It clung to everything.

His shirt. His hands. His hair. His throat.

"I didn't know there would be a fire," Thomas said again.

The officer looked at him carefully.

"But you locked him inside?"

Thomas's mouth went dry.

His mother sat beside him, one hand covering her lips. She had not stopped shaking since she arrived. Every few seconds, she looked at him like she was trying to recognize her own son.

Thomas stared at the floor.

"Yes."

The word was small.

Too small for what it meant.

The officer wrote something down.

"And you planned this?"

Thomas closed his eyes.

He saw the key in his palm.

The message on his phone.

Marshall's bag in the storage room.

The door closing.

The sound it made.

Final.

"Yes," he whispered.

His mother made a sound beside him, half breath, half sob.

Thomas wanted to reach for her hand, but he could not move.

He did not deserve comfort.

Not yet.

Maybe not ever.

The officer's voice softened, but not enough to make it kind.

"Did you intend to hurt him?"

Thomas opened his eyes.

"No."

The answer came quickly.

Too quickly.

Because it was true.

But truth did not fix the door.

Truth did not clear the smoke.

Truth did not bring Marshall back.

"I just wanted him to feel scared," Thomas said. "I wanted him to know what it felt like."

The officer looked at him.

"What what felt like?"

Thomas swallowed.

He thought of the notebook under the stairs. Marshall reading his words aloud. Justin laughing. Caleb watching. Students standing around like the pain was a show.

He thought of his phone being held above his head.

His mother's message.

Your dad would be proud of you.

Marshall's voice reading it to everyone.

He thought of all the times teachers said ignore him, as if being ignored by adults did not hurt almost as much as being laughed at by children.

"Helpless," Thomas said.

The officer stopped writing for a second.

Thomas looked down at his hands.

They were clean.

That felt wrong.

Then Thomas remembered Mrs. Allen's lesson.

The brain. Memory. Emotion. The final moments.

He had been sitting two rows ahead of Marshall that day, pretending to focus on his notes while the boys at the back turned death into another joke.

Seven minutes? Justin had whispered. *That's not even enough time to explain my homework excuses.*

Caleb had laughed.

Marshall had laughed too.

Then Marshall had leaned back in his chair, careless as always, and said, *If my life flashes before my eyes, I hope it skips school.*

Thomas had not laughed.

He remembered Mrs. Allen looking at Marshall for a moment, not angrily, not impatiently, but almost sadly.

Sometimes the memories we want to skip are the ones we need to face.

At the time, Thomas had written the sentence down without knowing why.

Now he knew.

The words returned to him in the corridor, with smoke still clinging to his clothes and police lights flashing against the school walls.

Seven minutes.

Had Marshall seen him?

Had he seen the notebook being snatched from his hands?

Had he heard the corridor laughing?

Had he seen the phone screen, the message from his mother, the part of Thomas's grief that should have stayed private?

Had he seen the storage room door closing?

Thomas swallowed hard.

A terrible part of him wanted the answer to be yes.

He wanted Marshall to have understood. He wanted Marshall to have felt regret. He wanted Marshall to have spent his final moments facing everything he had turned into a joke.

Then the thought made Thomas feel sick.

Because wanting Marshall to understand was not the same as wanting him to die.

And yet Marshall was dead.

Thomas pressed his hands together until his knuckles ached.

For the first time, he realized the punishment had not lasted ten minutes.

It had lasted a lifetime.

Not Marshall's.

His.

Something about him should have looked different. There should have been smoke under his fingernails, blood on his palms, proof on his skin that a boy had died because of something he had done.

But his hands looked normal.

That made it worse.

Across the corridor, Justin and Caleb stood near the wall.

For once, they were not laughing.

Justin's face looked grey. Caleb kept wiping his eyes with his sleeve, even though no tears were falling. They looked younger than Thomas had ever seen them. Younger than sixteen. Younger than the boys who had followed Marshall around like he was untouchable.

Justin looked at Thomas once.

Only once.

Then he looked away.

Thomas did not blame him.

A door opened near the office.

Marshall's mother came out.

The corridor changed.

Nobody told the students to be quiet. They became quiet by themselves.

She walked slowly, like each step had to be remembered before she could take it. Jenna was beside her, holding her mother's hand with both of hers. Her face was swollen from crying. Her school bag hung from one shoulder, forgotten.

Thomas could not breathe properly when he saw them.

Marshall's mother looked around the corridor as if she had entered the wrong place. As if someone had made a mistake. As if any second, Marshall would come around the corner laughing too loudly, saying it was all a joke.

But he did not.

Jenna looked at Thomas.

Not for long.

Just one second.

That was enough.

Thomas had imagined Marshall scared.

He had imagined Marshall shouting.

He had imagined Marshall finally understanding what fear felt like.

He had not imagined Jenna.

He had not imagined a little sister standing in a school corridor with her whole world broken open.

Thomas looked away first.

His mother touched his arm.

"Thomas," she whispered.

He flinched.

Not because she had hurt him.

Because her voice sounded afraid.

Of him.

That was when he understood something new.

Revenge did not give pain back.

It spread it.

It moved from one person to another, changing shape each time.

Marshall had passed his pain to Thomas.

Thomas had passed his pain back.

Now it had reached Jenna.

Marshall's mother.

His own mother.

The teachers.

The students.

Everyone.

And Marshall was still dead.

A few weeks later, Thomas stood in court.

He wore a shirt his mother had ironed the night before. She had ironed it carefully, even though her hands shook. She told him to stand straight, answer clearly, and tell the truth.

So he did.

He told them about the bullying.

He told them about the notebook.

He told them about the phone.

He told them about the message.

He told them about the key.

He told them he had planned to leave Marshall there for ten minutes.

He told them he had not planned the fire.

The judge listened.

So did Marshall's mother.

So did Jenna.

Thomas could not look at them for long.

When the judge spoke, the courtroom became so quiet that Thomas could hear his own heartbeat.

The judge said Thomas was young, but old enough to understand that locking someone in a room was dangerous. He said pain did not excuse revenge. He said bullying was real and serious, but taking justice into your own hands could destroy more lives than the one you meant to punish.

Thomas heard words like **juvenile detention, counselling, supervision, record, and responsibility.**

They moved around him like weather.

His mother cried silently.

Thomas did not.

He had cried enough before court.

He had cried in bed.

He had cried in the shower.

He had cried when he found his notebook and saw the page Marshall had read aloud.

He had cried when he remembered the sound of the storage room door closing.

Now he just stood there.

Empty.

When they led him away, he turned once.

Jenna was looking at him.

Her eyes were red, but steady.

For a second, Thomas thought she might hate him.

Maybe she did.

Maybe she had every right to.

But she did not shout.

She did not cry.

She just held something in her hand.

A small yellow toy car.

One wheel was missing.

Thomas stared at it.

He did not know what it meant.

Not then.

But Jenna held it like it was the last piece of her brother that had not been burned by what he became.

Later, people at school would talk about Marshall in different ways.

Some would remember the jokes.

Some would remember the bullying.

Some would remember the fire.

Some would say Thomas went too far.

Some would say teachers should have stopped it earlier.

Some would say Marshall deserved a lesson, but not death.

Some would say nothing at all.

Justin stopped sitting at the back of class.

Caleb became quieter.

Sophie changed seats and stopped looking over her shoulder so much.

Daniel heard what happened from another student and did not know what to feel.

Mr. Harris stood in front of the class one morning and tried to speak about choices, but his voice broke halfway through.

Mrs. Walker removed the kindness poster from the wall and replaced it with a blank sheet of paper. At the top, she wrote:

What kind of person do you become when people are watching?

Nobody laughed.

At home, Jenna kept the yellow car in her drawer.

Sometimes she took it out and rolled it across her desk. It never moved straight. It wobbled, turned, and fell onto its side.

She remembered a boy in the backyard making engine sounds with his mouth.

She remembered laughter before fear.

She remembered Marshall before he became a warning.

And that was the cruelest part of grief.

It did not let people become only one thing.

Marshall had been a bully.

Marshall had been a brother.

Marshall had been cruel.

Marshall had once made Jenna laugh so hard she could not breathe.

All of it was true.

Thomas learned the same thing behind locked doors of his own.

Not the same kind of door.

Not a storage room.

Not smoke.

Not fire.

But still a door that closed because of one choice.

At night, he sometimes heard Marshall's voice in his head.

Not shouting.

Not mocking.

Just asking nothing.

That was worse.

Thomas used to think guilt would sound like screaming.

It did not.

It sounded like silence.

It sounded like ten minutes.

It sounded like a door staying closed.

And every day after that, Thomas had to live with the truth that Marshall had never learned in time.

Pain does not disappear when you give it to someone else.

It only grows.

Seven minutes had ended one life.

One choice had changed all the others.

Author's Note

Seven Minutes is a story about choices, pain, and consequences.

I wrote this book to show that people are not always born cruel. Sometimes they learn to hide their pain in harmful ways. Marshall uses laughter to cover his fear and shame, but over time, that laughter becomes a way to hurt others.

I also wanted to show how fooling around in class, ignoring schoolwork, and acting like the future does not matter can slowly affect a person's life. What seems funny or harmless at first can become a habit that leads to bigger problems.

The final seven minutes force Marshall to face the memories and choices he avoided. In the end, he realizes that words, jokes, and actions can affect people more deeply than we think.

This novel was written with the help of AI tools (such as ChatGPT) for brainstorming, structure, editing, and language refinement. However, the story idea, characters, themes, and final creative decisions are my own.

— Jason Bram

A NOVEL BY JASON BRAM

*He laughed first.
He understood last.*

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Jason Bram is a student, writer, and creative designer with a deep curiosity about the human mind and the choices that shape who people become.

He is passionate about storytelling that is real, emotional, and thought-provoking. Through his writing, Jason explores themes such as bullying, memory, regret, family trauma, and the small decisions that leave a lasting impact.

Beyond writing, Jason loves designing visuals, creating ideas, listening to music, and watching films that inspire him. These creative interests help him build stories that connect emotions, words, and imagination.

Seven Minutes is his original novel, written to remind readers that every choice has a consequence and that change is always possible—no matter how dark the past.

ABOUT THE BOOK

Seven Minutes is a dark, emotional novel about a boy named Marshall who hides behind laughter while hurting the people around him. Bullied as a child and ignored by the world that should have helped him, he grows up using cruelty as his power.

After his death, Marshall is trapped in a storage room for seven minutes—seven minutes that force him to relive the memories he tried to bury.

In that short time, he must face the truth about his choices, the pain he caused, and the person he could have become.



*Some memories don't fade.
They wait.*



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